Shoot Your Shot

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/41289411.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F, F/M

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Hawkeye (TV 2021)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Yelena Belova/Kate Bishop

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Kate Bishop, Yelena Belova, Maria Hill, Lucky (Hawkeye)

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Shoot Your Shot

by Peter_Pandemonium

Summary

After the defeat of Prime, the Best Friend Squad (now featuring Catra) has been traveling through space to make sure any remaining clones are dealt with. When a ship of rogue clones escapes and starts heading for a distant planet, the BFS pursues them.

On Earth, Kate Bishop is trying to get back to some sense of normalcy.
She has a job, and a dog, and maybe a slight crush on a certain unattainable blonde ex-assassin.

On patrol one night, she crosses paths with some creepy looking dudes fighting with some very odd strangers.
Little does she know that she's about to get pulled into her biggest adventure yet.

Notes

This story is set in the universe established in the Hawkeye series, and events will take place mostly within New York City.

It picks up about 6 months after the end of the She-Ra series and about 3 months after the end of the Hawkeye series, which would be early 2025 on Earth.

I've attempted to keep everything mostly in alignment with show canon.

This story will contain spoilers for both the She-Ra and Hawkeye series as it is set after the end of both.

It isn't 100% necessary to have watched both series before starting this fanfic, but I do recommend it.

Partly because I really like both of them!

I've tried to add in a little explanation and context, but if you still have questions about either of the shows or things that I've referenced within the story, leave a comment and I'll try my best to explain.

My current estimate for this fic is seven chapters, and I will update the total chapter count as needed.

This is a stand-alone story unrelated to any of my previous stories in these fandoms.
If you like this, please check out my other She-Ra and Hawkeye fics.

See the end of the work for more notes

When Fates Collide

Shoot Your Shot

When Fates Collide

The stars whipped by as Darla continued uneventfully on her way through space, most of her passengers now ignoring the view after so many days of travel had made it lose its novelty.

The exception was Catra, who, as usual, was perched in a spot not really designated as seating, tail twitching slightly as she stared out at the points of light whipping by.

Across the room, Adora sat watching her, a faint smile on her face as she sprawled in the captain's chair.

Sensing her gaze, one of Catra's ears swiveled and flicked back at the blonde, though her eyes remained facing forward.

"You're staring again, princess. Didn't anyone ever teach you that it's rude to stare?"

Her voice was low with the barest hint of a purr, curling around each syllable of the word "princess" in a way that never failed to fluster her partner.

But Adora was finally getting better at flirting back.

"You could come over here and teach me."

Catra still didn't turn, but the rhythmic swaying of her tail betrayed her interest.

Adora continued, her tone teasing, "I guess I'll just keep sitting here and staring then…staring at my beautiful, smart, cute…"

When Catra suddenly whirled and settled into a crouch, Adora's voice trailed off, and she grinned, anticipating the pounce that

would come next.

But before that could happen, the door opened, and Glimmer bustled in, trailed by Bow.

"When are we getting there? Are we sure we're even going to the right place? There hasn't been any sign of the clones for days!"

Her eyes narrowed as she took in the tableau, and Catra quickly slid back down into a relaxed position pretending that nothing was happening.

"Hey! If I have to walk in on the two of you making out in the captain's chair again, I swear on the Moonstone that I will slap you both into next week. My poor eyes have already seen too much!"

"Dramatic as always Sparkles. Maybe when we get back home, you and Double Trouble can start your own theater troupe."

Glimmer scoffed, offended, and took a deep breath to wind herself up for (yet another) verbal sparring match with Catra, but Bow laid a gentle hand on her arm and she satisfied herself with a few angry mutters.

Having forged a temporary peace, Bow moved to stand next to Adora's chair, pressing a few buttons to call up a three dimensional map of the space they were traveling through.

"Entrapta's last transmission gave us the coordinates we're following. With Hordak's help she's been able to track the clone ship's signature, so we're going the right direction, we just have to keep following them until they stop."

"I hope they stop soon," Catra complained, "this little space trip is getting boring."

Glimmer nodded in solidarity.

Adora was busy manipulating the navigation map to see different views.
Eventually, she seemed satisfied, and pointed something out to Bow.

"If the clone ship stays on course, then it looks like they're headed for this solar system."

"Why would they want to go there? Is there something special about it?"

"Darla, do you have any records about the solar system we're heading for?"

The ship's voice replied a moment later.

"Greetings She-Ra. I have minimal records on this solar system. Known information is as follows: It contains one sun which is orbited by nine planets most of which also contain satellite moons. According to my database, only one of these planets is inhabited by humanoids. Please note that this information may be outdated."

"Thanks Darla," Adora said, absently, then looked around at her friends.
"That has to be where the clones are going. Hordak said that they might be trying to start a new cult of Prime, and it wouldn't make sense to do that somewhere where there wouldn't be any potential followers."

"I wish all the clones could have just turned out like Wrong Hordak," Glimmer mused, "all he wants to do is learn new recipes and cook for people."

"And he looks so cute in his little apron!" Bow added, nearly squealing at the memory.

A more serious look had come over Adora's face as she dismissed the navigation map.
Catra caught it and hopped down from her perch to cross the

room and sit down on one of the arms of the chair, dropping a hand to Adora's shoulder.

The blonde leaned into the touch almost unconsciously, and Catra's tail curled around to rest against her side, tapping a slow rhythm.

As it had in childhood, the motion calmed her, and after a small sigh, she said in an apologetic tone, "If I hadn't let the clones get away, we wouldn't have to be here. We could all be back on Etheria, safe, and not going to some strange planet."

Around the room, the other three each drew in a breath, ready to contradict her, but Catra was fastest.

"You defeated Prime and turned his whole ship into a gigantic, magic tree. You did more than enough."
Her words were emphasized by a strong squeeze of the hand still resting on Adora's shoulder, this time with just a hint of claws.

Unable to contain herself any longer, Glimmer burst out, "You saved all of us Adora! With Prime gone, most of the clones just shut down or wandered off to do their own harmless things. There was no way of knowing that some of them would decide they still had a mission."

Bow added, more gently, "We've been to lots of planets now and we've always figured it out. We're the Best Friend Squad."

Adora looked up at Catra and after a moment of silent communication between them, she leaned back in the chair, some of the tension leaving her body.
"You're right. Once we round up these last clones, we can head home."

"Why don't you get some rest Adora? We should get there sometime tomorrow. I'll stay up for now and make sure the clones don't change course."

Before Adora could protest, Catra answered for her.
"Thanks Bow. Let us know if anything weird happens."

With that, she stood, pulling Adora up with her and leading her off by the hand. Before they got to the door that led to the hallway, Adora paused and asked, "Darla, what is the name of the inhabited planet in the solar system that we're heading for?"

A moment later, the ship's calm voice responded.

"The planet is called Earth."

For someone with a mother in jail, a refrigerator with nothing of true nutritional value inside of it, and a new job as the figurehead of a company she had very mixed feelings about, Kate Bishop was having a pretty good day.

Her dark purple suit and matching combat boots had garnered admiring looks from the coolest baristas at her local coffee shop, Lucky hadn't rummaged through the trash while she was at work, and parts for some new trick arrows she was going to try creating had been delivered.

Now, she was returning home from walking her furry friend, thankful that it was Friday.

She closed and carefully locked the door of her new apartment, unhooked Pizza Dog from his leash, and tossed her keys on the counter.
After sloppily lapping some water from a bowl in the corner, her dog sat and whined at her until she gave him a stern look.

"I know you want pizza for dinner buddy, but I'm trying to keep you healthy. I know these dried pellets aren't as exciting, but they're good for you."

She dropped a few scoops of kibble in his bowl and he trotted over to eat it without protest.

"Or maybe I'm just projecting on you because I want pizza for dinner."

After kicking off her boots by the door, and wrestling her way out of her blazer, which she flung haphazardly onto one of the tall stools at the kitchen island, she flopped down on the couch starfish style to scroll through her phone.

There were a few random texts in the thread she had with her two best friends Franny and Greer that she took a minute to respond to.

The emails from Bishop Security, she decided to ignore until Monday. She was not her workaholic mother, and it wasn't like they really needed her to make any decisions.

In the aftermath of her mother's arrest, she'd had to talk to a lot of lawyers. Her mother had apparently set up a lot of contingencies in the event of her arrest or death, and that strategic planning meant that Kate was now heir to a sizable fortune, though most of it was being held in a trust until she turned 25. Her credit cards were at least unfrozen again, for which she would be eternally grateful.

The majority of the family business had also been sheltered from any entanglements with Kingpin's sweeping criminal enterprise, and as such, Kate was also now the heir to that business, though truthfully between the board of directors and senior management, she was left out of most of the day to day.

Still, she had a job with a fancy title (Vice President of Operations), which came along with a generous salary, and most importantly to her, continued high level access to Bishop Securities products and databases.

She was still figuring out how to act at work, as most people were either taken aback by her boisterous friendliness, or looked at her suspiciously because of her mother's legacy.
Or sometimes a combination of both.

Lucky had finished his kibble and hopped up onto the couch next to her, giving her a loving stare. She absently patted his head and scrolled through food delivery options with the other hand.

“What do you think, buddy? I should probably eat a vegetable, right?”

Lucky yawned in response.

“I know, right? Vegetables are boring. But I don’t want scurvy or weak bones or whatever.”

After a few moments of considering her choices, she opted for chicken stir fry and spring rolls from one of her local favorites.

“And, done!”

She bounced back off the couch and headed up the stairs to her bedroom loft to change into sweats.
Her new apartment was similar to the last one in size and layout, but it had an upstairs half-bath and a small spare bedroom downstairs.

The remainder of the downstairs was the open concept living room/dining room/kitchen and a training area with archery targets, a heavy punching bag, pull up bar, and mats for tumbling, and, theoretically, grappling. In the event that she ever had someone to train with at least.

Once she was ensconced in cozy purple sweatpants and a hoodie, she stared out the large window at the end of the bedroom.
It offered access to the roof, as well as a decent view out over the neighborhood. It was one of the main reasons she’d chosen this apartment, which took up the whole upstairs.

Downstairs was a small electronics repair shop run by a kind older man who minded his own business and left promptly at 5pm each day.

She had private access to her apartment, and she'd spent time setting up a security system that included alarms and exterior cameras that she could link to remotely.

The exterior door was reinforced steel and then there was another alarmed door at the top of the stairs that required an electronic code.
All of the security upgrades made her feel a lot safer, just in case anyone decided they still had a bone to pick with her.

She'd even updated the windows before moving in, so any future attempts to toss in Molotov cocktails would be unsuccessful.
One burned out apartment was enough.

On the nights she woke up from nightmares of being choked out by a large, shadowy figure or having hordes of gun-toting men chasing her through the city, she was extremely thankful for the added protection of her custom windows and doors, and the comforting green indicators on her phone when she checked her security app.

Kate stood staring out into the night for another few minutes before she turned away to descend the stairs and wait for her dinner to be delivered.

She spent the next few minutes tossing a stuffed pig for Lucky to fetch.

As she zoned out watching her pet happily chew on his favorite toy, her mind wandered to when she'd last seen Yelena.

The blonde assassin had been taking up a disproportionate amount of her brain space ever since they'd first met.
In all honesty, Kate had not been expecting to see her again so soon (if ever).

Three Months Ago

After the whirlwind of events leading up to Christmas, Kate had been glad to get out of the city for a few days.
Her time with Clint and his family hadn't been relaxing exactly, but she'd quickly been welcomed into the clan, and being there had been restorative.

She'd gotten back to NYC the morning of New Year's Eve.

A post-fire cleaning service had come into her old place while she was out of town and taken care of the destruction as best they could, so when she came back the water, ashes, and any unsalvageable furniture had all been removed.

Even though her friends were blowing up her phone, begging her to come out with them to ring in the new year, she'd politely declined, focusing on packing up as much of her stuff as she could in anticipation of her move to a new apartment.

Until the new place she was moving into had all the security upgrades installed, she'd decided to stay at her mom's penthouse. That building at least had a security guard and cameras and the Tracksuit Mafia shouldn't know to look for her there.

So after she'd done as much organizing and filling up boxes and garbage bags as she could stomach, she grabbed a backpack of essentials for herself and Lucky, and headed out.

It was cold, but she decided to walk and forego the huge upcharge that would come with calling an Uber on New Year's Eve.
About halfway there, she stopped outside one of her favorite pizza joints and stared in through the window, trying to decide how badly she wanted a slice of pepperoni.

When she noticed a reflection appear in the window from someone standing right behind her, she jumped hard enough that she almost headbutted the glass.

She spun, and there was Yelena, looking as beautiful and unruffled as always with her hair in an elaborate braided updo.

Under her green coat she was wearing a form-fitting dark gray sweater, black dress pants, and black boots with enough of a platform heel to bring her almost eye level with Kate.
She looked good. Very good.

And as one of her blonde eyebrows raised in apparent amusement, Kate hoped that her long silence and possibly gaping mouth would be interpreted as mere surprise versus blatant ogling.

“Kate Bishop. Fancy meeting you here.”

“I’m going to ignore that because I know you’re following me, or tracking me, or something. Wait, you aren’t here to kill me, right?”

“Oh, Kate Bishop, you’re so funny. Why would I want to kill you?”

“Because you’re an assassin? And my mother is a criminal. And I recently got wildly entangled with a local criminal organization whose terrifying boss nearly killed me with his bare hands.”

Yelena waved her hand dismissively as if none of that mattered.

“If I was going to kill you Kate Bishop…”

“I’d already be dead. Yeah, I get it. I know the line.”

There was silence as the blonde woman looked at her, with an expression that gave nothing away.

Then, she dropped to one knee and started petting Lucky, who nuzzled against her excitedly.
After giving him attention which included a kiss on the head and what sounded like a string of endearments in Russian, she stood again.

“It’s New Year’s Eve.”

“Yes? It is.”

“Is it not customary in America to drink on this holiday?”

“Uh…yeah, yeah, typically it is.”

Kate was now staring in confusion at Yelena, as the blonde woman smirked at her.
Unfairly, this made her even more attractive.

“Wait, wait, are you saying you want to get a drink? Like, together?”

“You did ask me out for a drink already. So I am just following up, no?”

Hearing the words “ask me out” coming out of Yelena’s mouth nearly short-circuited Kate’s brain again, but she managed to respond.

“Right, I sure did. Immediately before you kicked me in the chest, so I wasn’t exactly sure you took my offer seriously, you know?”

Now a deep chuckle came from Yelena.
“Kate Bishop, I always take offers seriously when they come from pretty ladies.”

Hearing those words, Kate was almost positive that she was dreaming, but as a cold wind whipped between the buildings and across her face like icy fingers, she decided that she was awake but possibly hallucinating.

In that case, she might as well go with it. Yelena probably wasn’t flirting with her, right?

Congratulating herself on her ability to string together several coherent sentences when Yelena was looking at her with those eyes, and talking to her with that mouth, she agreed to go inside and get pizza for both of them while Yelena wandered off to find someplace to buy alcohol.

Thankfully, this wasn't a difficult task, though the quality of said alcohol left something to be desired.

When Yelena returned, clutching a brown paper bag, Kate was waiting for her on a bench, several slices of pizza stacked on a plate and a huge wad of napkins protruding from the pocket of her coat.

The blonde seated herself with a grace that Kate envied, and pulled a bottle of cheap red wine from the bag with a dramatic flourish.
Kate had a brief moment of imagining Yelena as a magician, complete in a cape and top hat, and knew she would willingly dress up in the most obnoxious of sparkly gowns if she could be the lovely assistant.

Then that bottle was being waved in her face and her eyes refocused on Yelena's face, now marred by a slight scowl.

"I know this wine is garbage, but trust me, the only vodka in that store was pure swill."

"No, no, it's totally fine. Sorry, I completely spaced out. Here, have some pizza before it gets cold."

The blonde's expression smoothed out, and she cracked open the twist off cap and presented the bottle to Kate.
The archer accepted the bottle and took a long swig, wincing only slightly at the taste.

"Yeah, that's…that's some bodega wine."

She passed the bottle back to Yelena who lifted it to her in toast and took her own long drink.

"Yes, this is very bad Kate Bishop. Next time, I will take you out for a proper drink."

Kate's heart grew a size in her chest.
"Next time?" she asked, immediately cursing the breathlessness in

her tone.

Yelena pointedly ignored this, instead picking up the top slice of pizza.
"So, what is the proper New York City way to consume this large, flopping thing?"

With a smile, Kate showed her what she considered the ultimate folding technique, which included a carefully placed napkin to catch any dripping grease.

Yelena's commentary on the pizza: "Disgusting but more delicious than this wine."

After they'd finished the pizza, and Kate had given Lucky his own slice, ignoring Yelena's outrage, they started walking in the direction of her mom's penthouse, chatting about different places in the city that Yelena still wanted to visit.

When they got to the front door of the building, Kate stood with her keys in her hand, unsure of how to say goodbye.
Yelena had fallen silent as well, her eyes flicking up and down the street at all the passers-by.

Kate took a deep breath to say…something, when suddenly there came the boom of fireworks, people cheering, horns honking (more than usual), and a wave of other noise.

Kate pulled her phone out of her pocket and saw that it was midnight.
She looked back up at Yelena, excited.

"Happy New Year! Thanks for helping me ring it in. It was nice."

The smile that Yelena gave her in response was the biggest one Kate had ever seen on her face.

"Happy New Year Kate Bishop. I will see you soon."

Then, before the brunette could react, the assassin darted forward to press a kiss on each of her cheeks in turn.

Kate's face immediately flushed at the first touch of those soft lips on her skin, and she looked away to regain her composure.
By the time she looked back up, Yelena had vanished.

Still in a daze, Kate used her key fob to enter the building, waved distractedly at the guard at the desk and made her way up to the penthouse.

She fell asleep that night, still half-way wondering if she'd hallucinated the whole thing, while doing her best to replay every moment of the evening so she could indelibly commit it to memory.

Despite Yelena's words, Kate did not see her soon. However, she did get a text the next morning from an unknown number.

Thank you for the drink Kate Bishop.

Now, Kate snapped back to the present, shaking her head to dispel the longing that overtook her whenever she thought about the blonde woman for more than a second.

It was annoying, that feeling, especially when it was focused on someone she barely knew and hadn't seen in months.

They had texted back and forth a little over the weeks that followed New Year's Eve, with Kate doing her best to be extremely chill and not send more than two (or three) messages between each response from Yelena.

But their communication had suddenly ended, and her last few texts asking when Yelena would be back in town and if she was okay had gone unanswered.

She knew thinking about the blonde assassin was a futile exercise in gay pining, but who could blame her?

Yelena was the most intriguing woman she'd met, well, ever, and her quirks were wrapped up in a strong, beautiful package.
And she had an accent!
Kate would defy anyone, regardless of their sexuality, to not develop at least a small crush on her.

"Ugh, stop brain, just stop."

A welcome distraction came when the door buzzer sounded, and she looked at the front door camera to see the food delivery person waiting outside. Grabbing the retractable sword that Clint had somewhat begrudgingly passed along to her, she stuck it in her back pocket and went out to claim her dinner.

She then spent several hours eating, watching cartoons, giving Lucky extra attention (but not the spring rolls he really wanted), and decidedly not thinking about blonde assassins with beautiful eyes.

Send in the Clones

Chapter Summary

The Etherians make it to Earth and try to track down the clones.
Their presence does not go unnoticed.

Kate Bishop's routine neighborhood patrol ends up way more interesting than she'd anticipated.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Shoot Your Shot

Send in the Clones

All four of Darla's inhabitants stood on the bridge gazing out at the sight before them.
The planet in front of them was a large green and blue sphere that seemed larger than Etheria, though with all their time in space, it was hard to remember how big their home planet looked from this distance.

As they'd entered the solar system, Adora had activated the new cloaking feature that Entrapta had developed.

It wasn't necessary when they were traveling at full speed as they were basically undetectable at that velocity, but they weren't sure what to expect from Earth's technology and Darla's databases hadn't been able to provide any additional information.

The clone ship's trail had indeed ended on Earth's surface, and they were just waiting for Darla's sensors to track the signature through the atmosphere so they would know where to land.

"The tracking sequence is now complete. The ship's engine signature ends near the eastern edge of one of the larger land masses. Based on the prevalence of light sources and heat signatures, this area seems densely inhabited."

Adora made eye contact with each of her friends in turn and then took Catra's hand in hers.

"Everyone ready?"

Glimmer gave her an excited nod, Catra squeezed her hand, and Bow smiled and said, "Best Friend Squad does Earth!"

"Darla, take us down and land us somewhere near where that signature ends."

"Affirmative. Engaging landing sequence."

They'd landed and exited the ship without issue, leaving it cloaked and hovering a bit above the ground.

After a quick check with Darla to make sure they were safe to breathe without their spacesuits, they collected their essentials and made their way carefully down the ramp and off the ship.

The first thing they all noticed upon exiting was that Earth didn't smell great.
Catra's sensitive nose scrunched in an attempt to ward off the multitude of smells that suddenly assaulted them.

"Ugh, this is gross," Glimmer said in a low voice.

"It kind of reminds me of the Fright Zone, but worse," Adora added.

It was also loud, particularly after the silence of space, with a lot of sounds none of them could identify coming from all around. Though, thankfully, it seemed like the area where they had landed was currently deserted.

Bow pulled out his tracker pad and frowned at it for a few moments.

"There's way too many energy signatures here for me to get any good readings."

Adora looked around, hoping to see some obvious indication of where the clones might have landed, but there was no sign of another ship.

“Let’s go then. The sooner we find them, the sooner we can go home.”

“Should we split up?” Glimmer asked, clutching her staff nervously.

She still wasn’t totally sure how well her magic would work on this planet, as her attempts to wield it had varied widely along their journey.
Her staff was a solid and reliable weapon at least.

“We stay together,” Adora replied.
“There’s no telling what dangers this planet holds and I don’t want us to get separated.”

As if to emphasize her point, she placed a hand on her gauntlet, and with a quick flash of light, it transformed into a sword.
She let her free hand briefly rest on her partner’s shoulder, and then started walking towards the nearest building.
There were no lights visible through the windows, but irregularly placed exterior lighting provided patches of alternating shadows and illumination.

Catra stayed at Adora’s side, tail twitching as she tried to sort through the multitude of sounds and smells for any sign of danger.

Not far behind them, Glimmer and Bow had fanned out, weapons at the ready and gazes alert.
When they got to the door of the building, it was locked, and there was no way to see inside.

Adora wasn’t keen on the idea of damaging Earth property quite so soon, so she ignored the door and motioned towards the left.

“Let’s go around and see if there’s anything on the other side.”

Bow and Glimmer nodded, and followed as Adora started for the corner of the building, but at a quick hiss from Catra she froze.

“What’s wrong?”

Catra’s ears were swiveling quickly, her pupils large and dark.
“I don’t know…there’s something…”.

She’d just started to drop into a fighting stance when a group of clones appeared from around the side of the building and rushed towards them, eyes blazing with a fierce green light.

“Looks like we found them!” Bow yelped, and quickly fitted an arrow to his bowstring and fired, capturing one of the clones in a net and sending him flying.

Adora was battling two others, fending them off with kicks and swings of her sword.

As a third clone tried to drop in behind her, he was knocked to the side by Catra, whose claws were out now. A slash and he stayed down while she flipped back up to land next to Adora who had knocked her opponents away and was preparing to engage the next ones.

By now, Glimmer had entered the fray, whipping her staff with violent delight.
Catra took a moment to appreciate her smacking a snarling clone silly and then turned back to see Adora kicking the final clone into a heap of his brethren.

“Woohoo!” Glimmer cheered, jumping as high into the air as her short legs could manage.

Bow came trotting over, a smile on his face.
“Nice job team! That was…,” he trailed off as a new batch of clones came whipping around the corner.
“Too easy I guess,” Bow finished with a gulp.

“Okay, round two! Here we go!” Glimmer shouted, seeming less dismayed than excited.

Catra just grinned at her. Battle Glimmer was her favorite Glimmer.

With one quick breath, Catra charged forward, pouncing right onto the lead clone's chest and taking him to the ground.
Adora was there a second later, punching the next clone in the face with the pommel of her sword, bright blue eyes catching Catra's for a moment, a flash of love visible behind the determined anger.

With an impressive battle cry, Glimmer landed next to them, sweeping another clone's feet out from under him and bashing him several times once he was down.
Beyond her, the remaining two clones went down, hit with Bow's rope arrows.

"Nice one babe!" Glimmer called back to him.
Then she turned and pointed an accusing finger at the other two.
"No making out while I'm standing right here."

Catra smirked and took a step closer to Adora, running one hand along her bicep.
"No promises, Sparkles."

Glimmer inhaled, ready to snap back, but whatever remark she'd been about to say died on her lips as an even larger group of clones came pounding around the edge of the building and headed right towards them.

To make matters worse, some of the clones from the initial group that had attacked them were now starting to stagger to their feet.

Adora squared her shoulders and turned to face the oncoming group, Catra and Glimmer coming right up beside her.
An arrow flew over their heads and splashed the leading few enemies with a substance that stuck three of them to the ground and each other, and they thrashed as they were mostly immobilized.

"Sap arrow!" came Bow's shout from behind them.

Between the other three slashing, kicking, and whacking, plus several more regular arrows from Bow, all the clones were finally

either unconscious or immobilized.

Glimmer bent over trying to catch her breath and Bow came to check on her.
Adora's hair was disheveled and starting to fall out of her ponytail, but otherwise she was relatively unscathed.

Next to her, Catra was flexing one hand gingerly.
"My claws got stuck in one of their stupid robes, it's fine, I just twisted my wrist a little."

The taller blonde reached over and took her hand gently, running a thumb across her palm.
"I'm fine princess, really," Catra said in a softer tone.

"So," Bow said, slinging an arm around Glimmer's shoulders, "that was more clones than we bargained for. I didn't think that many escaped from the Velvet Glove."

Adora looked at the sprawl of clone bodies around them.
"Maybe the ship they escaped on had others on board?"

Bow was the one to reply as he remembered the information he'd gotten from Entrapta.
"The ship that landed here went straight from the Velvet Glove to this planet without stopping, so they must have already been on the ship."

Catra frowned.
"They can't make more, can they? Didn't all the technology get destroyed with Prime's ship?"

For a second, she remembered the unnatural green glow of that pool, and the pain of the conversion, and shuddered.
Adora's arm came around her then, and she leaned into the comfort.

"She-Ra removed his consciousness from the universe. Prime is gone. Forever."
Her words rang with conviction, and Catra exhaled in relief.

This relief was short-lived however, as she heard a new set of sounds approaching. She stiffened and pulled away from Adora's embrace.
"Guys, I think there's more!"

Catra's warning rang out just before yet another group of clones marched from around the building and then stopped, staring at the Etherians ominously.

"What are they doing?" came Glimmer's hissing whisper, watching the clones watch them.

"Is it time for She-Ra?" Bow asked nervously.

Adora was hesitant to call on She-Ra this far from Etheria in case something went wrong.
She still wasn't totally sure how to successfully summon her alter-ego this far across the universe, and the thought of not having access to the power if something happened to their ship was truly frightening.

That deeply ingrained worry might also be blocking her magic, but overthinking it didn't help matters, so for now, she satisfied herself with the magic necessary to summon and wield her sword.

"We can do this," Adora replied, hefting her sword and pointing it at the new group of clones.

Her friends lined up with her, readying themselves for the next attack.

Kate was restless. Maybe it was something in the humid, pungent city air or maybe it was that she'd skipped her morning workout after accidentally sleeping through her alarm.

After so many years of almost daily intense workouts, she needed movement or she started to feel twitchy.

She slipped on her Hawkeye suit, because it was comfortable, and she looked damn good in it, and strapped on her quiver and collapsible bow (thanks Clint).

The retracted sword was slipped into a special pocket along one leg, and then she was loaded up and ready to go.

One feature that she'd added to her suit was a mask that covered the lower half of her face. It was inspired by the Ronin suit and the necessity of not being recognized.

She didn't want to inadvertently end up with her face plastered all over the news if she could help it.

As she stepped out the door to the roof, she patted another pocket to make sure her phone was there.
Once she closed the door, she pulled out her phone and activated the security program, hearing the bolt on the door lock slide home with a satisfying click.

Tucking her phone away, she made her way across the roof and to a ladder she'd had installed on the side of the building.
Stepping over the short ledge at the roof's edge, she climbed down the first few rungs and kicked down. The ladder slowly started to extend, stopping when she was close enough to ground level for her to hop off and drop into the alley.

With a strong push to a cleverly hidden switch, the ladder started moving back upward, stopping about halfway up the building, well out of reach of anyone who might happen by.

One final check to make sure her gear was secure, and Kate was off, jogging quickly through a maze of alleyways and side streets, eyes open for anyone who looked like they were up to no good.

On past patrols, she'd stopped a couple of muggings and scared off a guy who looked like he was about to rough up his female companion.
But, more often than not, she just got a nice jog with a few parkour moves thrown in.

By now, she had a familiar route that she stuck to that kept her mostly out of sight. She'd made it through most of her usual circuit without incident and decided to get a better view of the remaining section of the neighborhood before heading back to her apartment.

There was a nearby warehouse building with a fairly accessible fire escape, so after muscling herself up onto it (thankfully she'd been doing a lot of pullups), she got to the roof and started walking around the perimeter.

As she approached one end of the building, the unmistakable sounds of a fight reached her ears and she started to run.

She made it to the edge of the roof and crouched down, peering over the edge.
Just across a gravel parking lot and along the side of the next building a cluster of four people were facing off with…

"What the shit are those things!?"

She shook her head as if that might help fix her vision.
But no, she could still clearly see the large group of identical looking, bone-white, pointy eared…people? Aliens? Aliens!?

They were now advancing in creepy silence towards the other people who at least looked more normal at first glance. One even had a bow!
On the ground all around them were incapacitated figures who looked the same as the rest of the white robed green-eyed… aliens?!

"Okay, those four must be the good guys, right? They look more like good guys than those other…guys."

Praying that her instincts were correct, Kate reached back to pull an arrow from her quiver.
"Here goes nothing."

With a fluid motion, she sent the arrow to the ground, right in front of the alien in the center of the formation.
On impact, the arrow exploded with a blast that sent their entire group flying through the air to land awkwardly, most of them not getting up again.

Kate allowed herself one triumphant fist pump before she ran for the fire escape.

By the time she got down to the ground and had sprinted to the site of the battle (thank god for all the cardio she'd been doing lately), the fight was nearly over.

She skidded to a stop and watched the four strangers finish off the remaining…alien guys.

When the last one went down with a groan and flapping of white robes, the four remaining people looked exhausted.

They were talking amongst themselves and Kate took the opportunity to look them over, which didn't last long, because one was whipping their head towards her and she realized, "Holy shit, it's a cat girl!"

Apparently, she'd said that out loud, because the four strangers immediately turned, raising their weapons.

Hoping that she wasn't about to get her ass kicked by aliens, she responded by lowering her bow.
Then, she pulled down her mask to reveal her face and raised her free hand in what she hoped was a universal sign of peace.

None of them had said anything yet, beyond a warning hiss from the cat girl (cat girl!), so Kate started talking in a calm voice.

"Hello. My name is Kate Bishop, and I don't know who those, um, people are who were attacking you, but…".

She trailed off as she realized that all of them were staring blankly.

Then, they started talking quickly amongst themselves, and she realized that she had absolutely no idea what they were saying. Their language was like nothing she'd ever heard before, flowing and musical.

They were gesturing at her, and the bodies littering the ground, and saying lots of things...apparently.

The cat girl had short, shaggy hair and was wearing a cool outfit in black and red tones.
Her tail was lashing around, and she was standing close to a blonde girl with her hair falling out of a ponytail.
That girl was holding a sword, which looked super cool, and she seemed to be about as tall as Kate.

The other two in the group were a short girl with pink hair wearing some kind of bodysuit in shades of purple.
She was holding a tall staff that Kate had seen her use to wallop some of the alien dudes.

The final member of the group was a taller boy in what looked like a crop top/body armor combo.
He was holding a golden bow that she really wanted to take a closer look at, so she hoped they could all be friends.

Even though she knew they couldn't understand her, she was a talker, so she said, "Hello, hi, again. I know you don't know what I'm saying right now, but hopefully we can figure that out because I'd love to know who you are…and who these guys are…and what the hell is going on here."

The five of them faced each other in a silent standoff, and then there was a sudden crackling sound that Kate felt more than heard, along with a flash of light that seemed to come from the blonde girl, who momentarily looked super tall and shining with rainbows.

Then the moment was over and Kate wondered if she had accidentally taken drugs and was hallucinating this whole evening.

Then it got even weirder.

The short girl looked around at her companions and said, "Did you all feel that?"

"Hey, I can understand you!" Kate blurted out, before she could stop herself.

They all whipped around to stare at her again, and it looked so comical, that Kate grinned.
Thankfully, this wide smile seemed to calm them down and they looked less angry and more confused.
Except for the cat girl. She just scowled and crossed her arms.

"Whoa!" the tall boy exclaimed. "Adora, did you do that?"

The blonde girl replied, "I don't know. If I did, it wasn't on purpose."

Kate, trying to be helpful, pointed out, "I saw you shoot out rainbows and get really tall for a second."

The blonde girl said, "It must have been She-Ra."

That made no sense to Kate, but the others all seemed like they knew what she was talking about.

She took a few cautious steps forward, hoping she wasn't about to get jumped.
"Hello. Could we start over, now that we can understand each other?"

The blonde girl did something that Kate's eyes couldn't follow, but the sword was just gone, and a shining golden gauntlet had appeared on her forearm.
Then she stepped up to Kate and extended a hand.

"Hello. I'm Adora."

Kate took her hand and shook it gingerly.
“Hello Adora. I’m Kate.”

As Kate had thought, they were the same height, and she looked into Adora’s bright blue eyes, feeling like this was someone she could trust.

With a nod, Adora stepped back, and the cat girl immediately came to her side, looping her arm around Adora’s waist possessively.

“This is Catra,” Adora said, looking down at her companion with a smile.

Catra had a striking face including two different, brilliantly colored eyes.
Her ears were flicking around, and Kate had a hard time looking away because…it was a cat girl…named Catra!

“And over there is Glimmer and Bow.”

Kate thought that their names were all a little too on point, but didn’t say anything.
Maybe where they were from, people got named for things about them?
Or maybe they were code names?

Kate gave them a casual wave, and they moved closer.
Like Catra, Glimmer had a scowl on her face, but Bow was smiling in a friendly manner, and ended up coming right up to her.

“Was that your arrow that took out the clones?”

“These guys are clones?”

For the first time, Catra spoke. Her voice was interesting, melodic and with a slight raspy underlay.
“You couldn’t tell from the fact that they all look identical?”

“Okay, it’s not every day I run into aliens. I don’t know how they’re supposed to look. Where are they from anyway? Where are you all from?”

Adora, Catra, and Glimmer all exchanged a look that Kate didn’t quite know how to interpret.

When they didn’t answer, Bow, who was clearly the friendliest, chided them gently.
“Guys, she helped us. I think we can talk to her.”

Appreciative of his efforts, Kate responded, “Thanks Bow. And yes, that was my arrow. I figured you all were the good guys, hopefully I was right. And I have a bunch of different trick arrows. I call that one the shock wave arrow.”

She swept a hand behind her to indicate her quiver, and then collapsed her bow in one smooth motion and attached it in its spot on her back.

Bow looked impressed as he watched this display.
“Oh wow! So cool! You have to show me your other trick arrows. I used a couple different ones in the fight just now.”

Kate followed his hand gesture and saw clones caught in ropes, one dangling in a net, and a couple stuck together in a sticky pile of goo.

“That’s my newest one,” Bow was saying proudly, “I call it a sap arrow, not that it’s actually sap, but…”

“Bow!”

That was Glimmer, who came stomping over a moment later and grabbed his hand.
Now that she was closer, Kate could see sparkles in her hair. They didn’t look like glitter, and Kate was just about to ask what was up with them when Glimmer’s angry face got uncomfortably close to her.

She craned her neck down as Glimmer said, with a bite to her tone, "Listen Earth lady, I'm sure you're a cool archer or whatever, but Bow is *my* boyfriend, so hands off."

The tips of Bow's ear turned red, and he said, in a somewhat embarrassed tone, "Glimmer, I'm just trying to be nice to the person who helped us."

For her part, Kate took a quick step back, and tried to defuse the situation.
"Oh, hey, not trying to cause any problems here. I'm just, you know, interested in archery. And cool trick arrows. Not in Bow, like not in that way I mean, because he seems very nice."

"Wow, she rambles more than you do," Catra said, poking Adora in the side.

She got an eye roll and a soft smile in return, and seeing that soft look Kate realized that holy shit, the cat girl and Adora were a couple.
Mind blown! Gay alien cat girl alert!

Looking back at Glimmer, she smiled in what she hoped was a reassuring manner and added, "Besides, you have nothing to worry about. I'm a huge lesbian."

This statement didn't have the impact that she was hoping for as all four of them looked at her blankly.

Glimmer muttered, "You're not that huge, I could take you."

Bow just squeezed her hand.

Then Adora asked, "What's a lesbian?"

Kate looked around and saw that they were all waiting for her response.
Apparently, she was about to come out to some aliens who she'd just met. And here she'd thought she was going to have a boring evening.

“Um, so…”.

The wheels in her brain were spinning wildly as she tried to figure out how to explain this concept to aliens who (mostly) looked like people.

But what was their gender? Did they have gender? Was sex different for them?
Was she about to give a sex talk to aliens in a deserted warehouse parking lot?

Before she could stutter out anything else, a deep, smoky chuckle sounded from behind her.
A shiver of anticipation ran down her spine right before the next words came floating out of the shadows.

“Kate Bishop, I am so interested to know how you got yourself into this one.”

Chapter End Notes

The Best Friend Squad is on Earth!

Kate Bishop meets aliens!

Yelena is here and she heard Kate say she was a lesbian!

Little Problems

Chapter Summary

Yelena gets pulled into the situation.

Kate tries to make friends.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Shoot Your Shot

Little Problems

The landing of the small quinjet had been almost silent, and Yelena popped the hatch and hopped down to the warehouse rooftop just in time to see a familiar figure dashing around the corner of the opposite building and confronting four potential enemies with only overwhelming friendliness and a bow.

The ex-assassin shook her head at the girl's foolish bravery, but an affectionate smile played across her lips.
Tapping her earpiece to activate comms, she reported in.

"I'm at the site. There are four unknown entities and many disabled potential hostiles."

"Copy that. The team will be there in T-minus ten minutes. Secure the area. No one leaves."

"Affirmative."

Yelena tapped the earpiece again to silence it, not wanting the distraction as she moved into position.
She rappelled down the side of the building and hid in the shadows behind a truck.

As Kate approached the four figures, Yelena let the interaction play out, though one hand was gripping a throwing knife in case a threat suddenly materialized.

But the four people, while oddly dressed, did not seem to be interested in attacking the human attempting to communicate with them.

Yelena's eyes ran over the four, assessing them for potential strengths and weaknesses, then she whispered, "Holy shit, is that

a cat girl?”

As Yelena stealthily crept closer, careful to stay out of view, one of the four suddenly spoke in English.
She listened to the rest of their exchange, and watched as Kate Bishop tried to make friends with one of the people, who was also carrying a bow. Another Hawkeye poser?

This one had a big heart on his chest (literally), and his entire stomach was exposed.
What kind of warrior was this?

When the tiniest member of the quartet started to get in Kate Bishop’s face, Yelena’s grip on her knife tightened and she crept even closer, ready to burst out of her hiding spot.

That one might be the shortest, but Yelena had learned that the small ones could be the most dangerous.
She herself had once been the greatest child assassin in the world after all.

Acting wisely for once, Kate took a step back as she tried to defuse the situation.

Yelena was about to step forward and reveal herself when she heard the words, “I’m a huge lesbian.” come from Kate Bishop’s lips.

She froze, and her heart gave a strange and annoying stutter in her chest.

It wasn’t that she didn’t think that Kate was attracted to her on some level.
She’d been trained since she was young to recognize and exploit other’s desires, and she was well aware of how she looked. Modesty was a waste of time as far as she was concerned. But her body had been a tool for so long, that it was hard to see attraction as positive.

What little time she'd spent with Kate had felt positive though . And now, hearing confirmation that Kate was in fact attracted to women, was making her feel something.

She wasn't exactly sure that feeling was, but she'd have to try and examine it later.
This wasn't really the moment for an emotional epiphany.

As Kate stood there trying to figure out what she could possibly say next, Yelena stepped forward out of the shadows.
At the sound of her teasing question, the younger woman spun, and a series of emotions flashed across her face too quickly for Yelena to follow.

Finally, her features settled into an exasperated smile.

"Of course this is when you decide to show up again!"

The four strangers had all tensed when she appeared, but they relaxed again at Kate's words.
Yelena moved to stand beside her, looking at each of the four strangers in turn.
Except for the cat lady, they all looked mostly normal.

Kate now gestured at her like she was introducing a newly arrived party guest.
"Everyone, this is Yelena. She's my…friend. Yeah, my friend."

"Wow, we are friends now Kate Bishop?"

The brunette turned to her with an annoyed look and hissed, "Yelena, I'm trying to keep the peace and you are *not* helping!"

Yelena just gave her a smirk.
"Don't worry Kate Bishop, there is backup on the way. No need to deal with this intergalactic threat on your own."

"Backup? Wait, what backup?"

As if on cue, the area around them lit up with spotlights as dark clad figures appeared around them, forming a loose perimeter.

The four strangers immediately shuffled closer together and readied themselves to fight.

Kate took a few steps towards them and raised her hands up in the air.

"Whoa, whoa. Everyone stay back. Yelena, what's going on?"

"Everything is okay. It is just S.H.I.E.L.D. coming to check on these space visitors."

The brunette lowered her hands, looking slightly relieved.
"So they are from space? I knew it!"

There was a beat as she looked around and then her head whipped towards Yelena.
"Wait, you're working for S.H.I.E.L.D. now?"

"I would say more that I am working *with* them."

One of the figures from the perimeter stepped forward and into the now well-lit area, and Kate's eyes widened.

"Oh my god! Maria Hill?!"

The woman gave her a tight smile and then focused her attention on Yelena.
"Status report."

The blonde replied in a cool tone, "As you see, the potential hostiles are disabled, and these four have not demonstrated any violence towards humans."

Director Hill's eyes took in the fallen clones and she made a hand motion.
A squat black van started to drive over slowly with several S.H.I.E.L.D. agents walking alongside.

“Hey, wait! What are you doing?”

“We’re going to collect these combatants and bring them somewhere where they can’t hurt anyone.”

“Hang on. What about them?”

Kate pointed over to the cluster of the other four, who were still standing silently and looking pretty freaked out.
“They know about these alien guys and they’re my friends. Well, we just were talking and they could be my friends, maybe. They seem okay. You can’t take them to a weird secret lab or something!”

Director Hill looked a bit taken aback by Kate’s passionate outburst.
“Our goal isn’t to kidnap our visitors, but we need to determine why they came here and whether they pose a threat. S.H.I.E.L.D. recognizes the sovereignty of other planets so long as they citizens obey our Earth laws.”

She took a few steps towards the four and Kate stuck to her side like glue.
“Can I help you? I’ve already established contact with them, and I helped them fight these guys…they called them clones.”

Yelena had to work hard to keep a smile off her face as she trailed a few steps behind, still watching Kate’s back even though the threat appeared to be neutralized.

The older woman considered Kate seriously.
“You’ll keep talking no matter what I say won’t you?”

“I mean…called out, but yeah.”

Yelena could see Maria Hill’s shoulders move as she heaved a sigh.
Another woman who was no match for the tenacious chatter of Kate Bishop.

The Director now stood facing the line of four figures, who were watching the humans with varying degrees of hostility and curiosity.

“Hello. Can you all understand me?”

Adora was the one to answer.
“We can.”

“Good. My name is Maria Hill and I’m the director of an agency here on Earth called S.H.I.E.L.D. We tracked a ship landed near here a few hours ago, and then a second ship not long after that. Was one of those your ship?”

“Yes, we were the second ship to land. We were tracking these clones. They escaped after a battle near our planet Etheria, and we wanted to capture them before they could harm anyone.”

“Etheria. That’s a new one. And what is your mission here?”

Now Glimmer replied, apparently taking offense to the questioning.
“We came here to stop the clones, like Adora said!”

Unfazed, Director Hill continued.
“And after you stop them, you plan to return to your planet?”

“Yes,” Adora said, before Glimmer could say anything else.
“We just want to go home.”

Catra had been prowling around some of the fallen clones nearest to her, and now she spoke to her companions.
“It looks like these clones have all deactivated.”

“What does that mean?” Kate asked. “Are they robots?”

Now Bow was the one to answer.
“Definitely not robots. More part of an ancient collective consciousness. They were all cloned from some prototype. But the leader is gone. Adora destroyed him.”

“Most of the remaining clones deactivated when that happened,” Adora added, “but some started living new, peaceful lives. This group though, they came here, to this planet. But we don’t know why.”

“Is this all of them?” Director Hill asked, before Kate could ask any more of the questions that were clearly about to burst from her mouth.
She was now bouncing on her toes with barely contained excitement.

“We didn’t find their ship and we don’t know if they are more. This is already more than we expected to be on board.”

“If we take these clones, will that be a problem?”

“No, take them all,” Catra responded, her voice tight with disgust. She’d come back to Adora’s side, and the taller woman wrapped an arm around her.

The S.H.I.E.L.D. agents began loading the fallen clones into the van, making quick work of it.

“Our agency will take over the search for this ship and any remaining clones that are on Earth. The four of you are free to leave and return to your home planet.”

All four of the Etherians began to immediately protest, joined by Kate.

Director Hill raised her hands and tried to talk over them, but could not compete against all of them together.
Finally, one voice raised above the rest. It was the short, sparkly person.

“Hey!!! Listen!”

Surprisingly, everyone else fell silent.
Glimmer stepped forward and stared aggressively at Director Hill.

“We came here to stop the clones and we’re not going anywhere until we’re sure that the mission is complete. We don’t want to fight any Earth people, but we will if you get in our way.”

Maria Hill remained impressively unruffled as she considered the four Etherians before her.

“Alright. We won’t force you to leave. But I do need to ask that you stay in a secure location while we continue the search for this missing ship. We can’t just allow you to wander around New York City.”

Glimmer looked back at her companions and they seemed to come to some unspoken agreement.

“We agree to these terms. But you have to tell us when you find the ship. We need to get on board so we can examine it.”

“That’s a reasonable request. Now, we can arrange a safe house for you where you will remain until…”

“They can stay with me!” Kate interrupted in an excited shout.

“What?” asked Director Hill, taken aback.

“What?” Yelena echoed a second later, sounding concerned.

Now Kate whirled around to try and encompass everyone in her appeal.
“My apartment is secure with a state of the art security system and a private entrance so no one will see us. And it’s really close by, so it’s near your search area for added convenience. Oh, and I’m basically like a junior Hawkeye, so it would be kind of like an Avenger was on duty.”

As Yelena watched Director Hill’s face, she realized that the woman was actually considering the request.

“Director,” she started to say in protest, but it was too late.

The director looked from the Etherians, to Kate, and then back to the Etherians.
"Are you willing to go with Kate Bishop and stay with her until we find the ship?"

Kate turned her highest wattage, most convincing smile on them.

"Okay," said Bow and Glimmer at almost exactly the same time, though Bow's response was markedly more enthusiastic.

Adora took a moment to look Kate up and down, and seemed to find whatever she saw acceptable, because she nodded.

Finally, Catra muttered, "Yeah, whatever."

"Alright," Director Hill said. "There's one condition."

"Yes, anything," Kate said.

"Agent Belova will be staying with you until this clone threat is handled."

"Now wait…"

"That isn't…"

Yelena and Kate were both interrupted by a piercing glare.

"I'm glad that's settled."

Then Adora raised her hand.
"Um…what about our ship?"

"What ship?" Kate asked, looking around.

Adora cleared her throat and announced, "Darla. Disengage stealth mode."

The ship suddenly appeared hovering low in the sky and nearly above their heads.

“Oh. That ship.”

They ended up taking Darla to Kate’s building and leaving the ship hovering just above the roof with the stealth mode re-engaged.

Then the party of six crossed the roof to the door Kate had left through what seemed like a lifetime ago.

“Oh my god, I have so many questions for you! Oh, we can have a sleepover…it’s going to be so great!”

She swiped a key card in front of the electronic pad by the door and the bolt slid open.

“C’mon in!”

Kate led the way with Adora right behind, and the rest of the Etherians in single file after her, with Yelena trailing them like an angry shadow.

“So this is the upstairs, which is really just my bedroom. Everything else is down here.”

The Etherians were looking around with interest as they followed Kate down the staircase to the lower level.

Once they got to the main floor, there was the sudden scrabble of paws heading towards them.

Kate had a split second to internally scream, “oh shit, how did I not remember about my dog and oh shit I have a literal cat girl with me” before Lucky charged around the corner with a joyful bark.

Catra instinctively scrambled up Adora like she was a tree and ended up awkwardly perched on her shoulders, tail puffed up.

Lucky noticed her movement and turned from where he was licking Kate's hand to run for Adora and Catra instead.

"Lucky, no! Stop! Down!"

Though he was normally a very sweet and well-behaved boy, Lucky had never encountered a magicat before.

He started jumping up towards Catra who was hissing and swiping at him while Adora yelped incoherently and tried not to fall over.

Then Yelena stepped forward and shouted out a stern command in Russian, and Lucky immediately ceased his excited yips and sat.

Kate's mouth dropped open.
"How did you do that? Are you a dog whisperer?"

Yelena shrugged.
"I just told him what to do and he did it. He respects my authority."

The brunette eyed her for a moment, but let it go in favor of her guests.

"I am so sorry Catra. And everyone. I forgot to warn you about Lucky. He's usually very calm, but he's never been around a cat… person before. Sorry, is there something besides "cat person" that I can call you that isn't offensive?"

Keeping both eyes fixed on Lucky, Catra slid down from Adora's shoulders, but stayed behind her.

"I'm a magicat. What is that thing?"

"Lucky is a dog. Do you not have dogs on Etheria?"

Everyone shook their heads.

"Oh…well…they're common pets here. They're domesticated from wolves…you know what, never mind. He's my pet and if he

bothers you I can put him in my room."

Adora had hesitantly reached out and when Lucky made no further attempts to jump on her, started to gently pat his head. When he gave her a gentle lick on the wrist and flopped over to let him pet her belly, she let out an "Awwww."

"Yeah, see, he's really a sweetie."

Bow quickly followed Adora's example and soon they were both on the floor giving Lucky attention.
Glimmer kept a suspicious distance and Catra looked distinctly unimpressed.

The tableau was interrupted by Yelena.
"Kate Bishop, I will take your dog for a walk. Why don't you get your guests settled in?"

At the word "walk", Lucky stood up and trotted to the door expectantly with Yelena following. Kate trailed after her.
"Okay, well take the extra key fob so you can get back in."

Yelena grabbed it from its hook by the door and clipped Lucky's leash on.

"Oh," Kate continued, "the code to the other door is…"

"Kate Bishop, do you think I don't know your door code?"

She smirked and headed out the door, leaving Kate sputtering after her.

Yelena led Lucky down the short hallway and through the door at the top of the stairs, closing it carefully behind her.
Once she was out on the street with the front door closed behind her, she allowed herself a low groan of frustration.

Lucky looked up at her, concern in his one brown eye, and she gave him a quick, reassuring pat.

"I'm sorry boy. It's not you. It is your beautiful and frustrating mama."

After a quick look around revealed that no one had overheard her, Yelena relaxed, ever so slightly.

She started down the block at a leisurely pace, letting her canine companion sniff all the light posts and fire hydrants he wanted.

"I think your mama is a magnet for trouble. She was being nosy and got mixed up with the Ronin suit and then Clint Barton and mobsters. And tonight she goes out on a walk and finds aliens and invites them home with her."

They walked for another block in silence before Yelena spoke again, this time in a more thoughtful tone.

"Though I suppose if Kate Bishop was not so reckless we would have never met. This would have been a shame."

As if responding to her words, the golden retriever sat down and nosed against her hand until she kneeled down and stroked his soft ears.

Taking his head gently between her hands she whispered to him. "Now, this is all between us, okay? You are a good boy. One day I will introduce you to my dog Fanny."

Yelena stood and turned back towards Kate's apartment.

"Let's go home."

The door closed behind Yelena, and Kate turned to face the others.

"Okay! Let me just show you where the bathroom is and stuff. Hopefully you brought pajamas, because I don't think my clothes are going to fit all of you."

Thankfully, they had each brought a bag of clothes and necessities with them from their ship.

Kate showed them the bathroom and how to turn on the faucet and the shower.
There was also an awkward minute where she tried to explain the toilet and what it was for, where she thought maybe they were messing with her, but it was hard to tell.

They got through the rest of the tour quickly, considering it was mostly just Kate showing them where they could find water glasses and extra blankets.

Then Bow and Adora had done their best to help her set up the sofa bed, and by the time Yelena got back, they were all lounging around the living room making somewhat awkward conversation.

Lucky tried to make another approach towards Catra, thankfully calmer this time, but she quickly leaped up to the back of the couch and out of reach.

"Sorry, sorry," Kate apologized, calling Lucky over to sit next to her.

She tried to make conversation with them for a few more minutes, but even her natural outgoing nature wasn't able to overcome the strangeness of the situation they found themselves in.

Especially with Catra keeping an eye on Lucky like he was more dangerous than she was (as if Kate hadn't seen those claws), and Yelena standing like a silent sentinel at the edge of the room.

Bow was clearly making an effort, with Adora occasionally joining in, but Catra's suspiciousness, Glimmer's aggressive posture, and Yelena's impression of a disapproving statue eventually wore everyone down.

Kate decided that maybe a little space and some sleep would help things, so she showed the Etherians the spare room and left it to them to figure out who was going to sleep where.

They immediately began a hushed conversation and Kate walked over to the bottom of the loft stairs to give them some privacy, pulling Lucky along with her.

To her surprise, Yelena followed her and stood facing her at an angle where she could still see the Etherians out of the corner of her eye.

"Kate Bishop. I will stay down here and keep my eyes on these Etherians, if you wish to sleep."

The taller woman gave her an exasperated look.
"If they want to leave, they'll have to get through several alarmed doors. And if they want to get to the roof to get to their ship, they'd have to come up through my bedroom."

Yelena's expression was stony as she responded.
"I expect you are telling me this for a reason?"

"Yes. If you want to be in the most strategic position, you should come upstairs with me. Then you can guard me *and* the access to their ship. Because, let's face it, they aren't going anywhere without that."

Considering she was inviting Yelena to her bedroom, Kate managed to keep her voice casual. And maybe she imagined it, but she thought there was a softening of the expression on the blonde woman's face.

The only response she got though was, "Fine."

Rolling her eyes, Kate walked a few steps away and asked, "Are you all set to sleep? Do you need anything else?"

The Etherians looked at each other and then Bow, apparently having been elected their spokesperson for the moment, gave her

a smile and said, “We’re good. Thank you.”

“Okay, if you need anything, just yell. I’ll see you in the morning.”

With that, Kate whistled to Lucky and he went running up the stairs with her following behind.
Yelena gave the Etherians one last almost-glare and then walked up the stairs as well.

Once the humans and the dog had disappeared and they heard the sound of a door closing, both Catra and Glimmer relaxed slightly.

Then Glimmer said, “I don’t like this. There might still be more clones out there. And are we sure we can trust these people?”

Ever the peacemaker, Bow offered, “I think we can. Well, Kate at least. She did help us before any of the others showed up.”

“You just trust her because she’s also an archer,” Glimmer said, but her tone was affectionate.

Bow slung an arm around her.
“You know that archers are the best kind of people.”

Now Adora said, “Right now we don’t have a choice but to work with them. If they can actually find the ship, then we should be able to leave soon. It is their planet, we have to follow their rules.”

Catra sighed.
“Still following orders, huh?”

After a raised eyebrow from her partner, she continued, “You’re not wrong though. We have to work with them, at least for now. I think Kate is okay, even if she talks too much. I don’t trust the other one though. She could be trouble.”

Any further conversation was interrupted by a big yawn from Glimmer.
"Can we just go with it for tonight and figure things out tomorrow?"

With that, they split up to use the bathroom and change into sleeping clothes.
Adora and Catra took the guest bedroom while Bow and Glimmer agreed to sleep on the sofa bed.

Once they were tucked under the covers, Catra curled into Adora and nuzzled her head into her partner's shoulder.

"I'm so ready for this to be over," she admitted, in a small voice.

"I know. Me too. I want…," Adora sighed and wrapped her arms around Catra, pulling her in even closer. "I want some time with you. Just to be together."

"I want that too," came the soft response, followed shortly after by a kiss. And then another.

In the living room, Glimmer was huddled up against Bow's side.

"I wish this was over. I wish we could just go home."

Bow sighed.
"Me too."

They snuggled together, relaxing as they sank into a warm bubble under the blankets.

As Bow was drifting off, he heard Glimmer's sleepy voice say, "I think there's magic on this planet. It feels strange, not like home… but there's something here…"

Upstairs, Kate came out of the half-bath in a worn archery team T-shirt and purple pajama pants to find Yelena standing near the bedroom door, scowling slightly as she absently stared at the floor.

In the corner of the room, Lucky was curled up in his dog bed, paws working slightly as he dreamed.

As Kate entered the room, Yelena quickly looked up.

“You can have the bathroom now. Do you need some pajamas?”

The question seemed to take Yelena off guard and her scowl deepened slightly.
“No, no…I can wear…”.

Her hand made a sweeping gesture in front of her body to indicate whatever it was that she meant.
Considering she was wearing a tactical suit, it wasn’t clear exactly what she thought pajamas were.

Kate sighed, crossed to her dresser, and pulled out a pair of black sweatpants and another t-shirt.
She crossed over to Yelena and stuffed the clothing into her arms, giving her a nudge towards the bathroom.

As the blonde opened her mouth, Kate interrupted, “Just humor me, okay?”

Yelena disappeared into the bathroom for a few minutes, and when she returned, Kate was in bed, propped up against her pillow.

She was wearing the clothes Kate provided, and the way they fit her given their different heights was pretty adorable actually.
Not that Kate would ever say that to Yelena, no, absolutely not.

The blonde carefully folded up her tactical suit and walked around the room, stashing various weapons as she went.

Kate didn't comment given that her bow and quiver were propped up next to her bed, and the retracted sword was placed carefully on her nightstand.

Once she was satisfied with her weapons placement and had checked that the bedroom door was locked, Yelena crouched down on the floor between the door and the end of the bed.

In response, Kate sat up straighter in bed and stared down at her. "What are you doing?"

"I will sleep on the floor. It is fine."

"Don't be ridiculous. You're sleeping in the bed."

"No, I am fine here."

"It's a king bed. I have extra pillows. Look, you can still sleep between me and the door."

The blonde did not reply.

Kate army crawled to the end of her bed and peered down at Yelena, who was now lying stiffly on the floor.

"Get up here."

No response.

"Get in the bed."

A long, aggrieved sigh.

Kate patted the bed invitingly.

Yelena finally stood, and with movements that were lacking her usual fluid grace, walked to the side of the bed and got under the covers.

Kate knew better than to tease the other woman further when she'd won such a sweeping victory, and merely got back under

the covers and switched off the lamp.

“Goodnight Yelena.”

A long beat passed and then came the soft response.
“Goodnight Kate Bishop.”

Chapter End Notes

And there was one bed...

When in Rome

Chapter Summary

Kate and Yelena grow a little closer.

The Etherians learn about coffee and pancakes.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Shoot Your Shot

When in Rome

As she surfaced from a dream she couldn't remember, Kate's still fuzzy brain slowly became aware of a solid warmth pressed against her back.

She was laying on her side and as her brain caught up with reality, she became suddenly aware that what she was feeling was Yelena spooning her.

She barely caught herself from shooting upright as her heart leapt in her chest.
Because Yelena was *spooning* her. Spooning. Her.

Kate's eyes flicked down to look at the arm wrapped around her waist and all her senses suddenly felt heightened.

The sound of Yelena's soft breathing, the pressure of that muscular arm against her body, and the hint of some rich, smoky smell all came into sharp focus.

If she could have turned around without waking the other woman, there's no doubt she would have been tempted to do something at least borderline creepy, like smell the other woman's hair, or stare at her while she slept.

But assuming that any motion might wake Yelena, she decided to just lay there, enjoying the warmth and the surprising sense of peace that washed through her.

Without even realizing it, she drifted back to sleep. She woke again to hear someone moving around the room, and cracked open an eye to see Yelena dressed in a pair of her gym shorts and a hoodie.

When Kate sat up in bed, Yelena whirled, seeming startled.

"I had to borrow some of your clothes, Kate Bishop. My tactical suit is not good for morning dog walking."

"Of course. Borrow whatever you need."

Kate was secretly thrilled to see Yelena in her clothes (again).

"Thank you."

The blonde looked over at her, but when her gaze met Kate's, it quickly skittered away again.
"I will take Lucky out and then we can interrogate our space guests."

She snapped her fingers and Lucky obediently trotted over to sit by her side.

"I think what you mean is have breakfast with them, maybe get to know them? Make them feel welcome on Earth. Decide how to help them with this clone finding mission."

Yelena shifted from foot to foot, less composed than Kate had ever seen her.
"I will leave the friend making to you. I will be back soon. Be careful around the aliens."

With that, she quickly left the room and Kate flopped back onto the pillows, confused.
Granted, she'd never seen Yelena first thing in the morning before, but she'd seemed almost nervous?

Then it suddenly hit her. Yelena had been spooning her when Kate had woken up.
Had she still been spooning Kate when *she'd* woken up?

This required more thought. And coffee. Definitely coffee. Maybe pancakes too.

Marching through the streets with Lucky in tow, Yelena allowed herself to revisit the feeling she'd had that morning when she'd woken up snuggled up to Kate Bishop.

Or, to be more specific, she'd woken up with her arms wrapped around the younger woman, holding her tightly, with her face pressed into the back of Kate's neck.
Just the memory of it made her body feel warm.

She scowled, and sighed, annoyed that her highly trained body had betrayed her in sleep.

Being physically close to someone that she wasn't actively fighting was still a novelty, and she had never woken up in a bed with someone, not since she was a very small child and had crawled into bed with Natasha when she'd had a nightmare.

With most people, she felt an innate urge to create distance, to make sure there was physical space between them.
But she found herself wanting to touch Kate and have Kate touch her.
It felt easy and she craved it in a way that was also foreign to her.

Having these confusing and complicated feelings was not what she needed right now, with visitors from another planet and hostile clones, as well as her current obligations to S.H.I.E.L.D.

As if on cue, her phone vibrated in her pocket, and when she answered, Director Hill's cool voice greeted.

"Good morning. What's the status report?"

"Good morning director. The Etherians continue to remain non-hostile and have not revealed any weapons or plans beyond the mission they stated last night."

"Continue to monitor them. Do not let them go off into the city unescorted. Report to me immediately if they become hostile or if

you believe that they have lied to us about their intentions."

"Understood. Have you located the clone ship?"

"Not yet. But we've found a new signature that we're tracking. As soon as we know more, I'll call you."

With that, Director Hill hung up and Yelena let out a slow exhale. She was going to need to continue to be around Kate Bishop. She could do that. She just needed to remain detached and professional.

Then she glanced down at herself, and her baggy gym shorts and combat boots combination. She also needed some different clothes.

Thankfully, the hotel she'd been staying at was close by.
A quick stop to pick up her clothes was definitely in order.

Not long after Yelena and Lucky left, Kate rolled out of bed and quickly got dressed in some purple joggers and an old archery championship t-shirt that she'd ripped the sleeves off of.
After putting her hair up in a ponytail and tucking the retracted sword into her pocket, she quietly made her way downstairs.

She didn't hear any sounds coming from the main floor, so it seemed that her guests hadn't woken up yet. She tiptoed past where Glimmer and Bow were huddled up and sleeping on the sofa bed and started rummaging through her cabinets and the fridge as quietly as possible.

Thankfully, she'd just gone to the store, so there should be enough eggs for everyone, and there was pancake mix in the back of a cabinet.

She started setting out what she'd need to cook breakfast, but decided to wait to actually make food, because who knew what Etherians actually ate? Instead, she focused on making coffee,

mostly because she wanted to jump start her brain before interacting with Yelena again.

Waking up in the other woman's arms was an experience she was desperate to repeat, preferably in a situation without people from other planets downstairs and with Yelena kissing her good morning.

But for now, all of that needed to be compartmentalized. There was a mission at hand.

Once she had coffee brewed and a cup poured, she walked across the apartment, intent on sitting by the window in her training area while she waited for either Yelena to return or her guests to get up.

As she rounded the corner though, she startled and almost spilled coffee on herself as she caught sight of a blonde ponytail.

The owner of said ponytail whipped around at the sound of her footsteps and gave her a tentative smile.

Kate was the first one to offer a greeting.

"Good morning…Adora. Wow, you surprised me. I didn't think anyone was up yet."

"Good morning Kate. I heard the door open and the dog walking around, and I couldn't go back to sleep. I'm sorry for scaring you."

Kate crossed over and leaned against the brick wall near the other woman, setting her coffee cup on the windowsill.

"It's okay, no worries. How did you sleep?"

"Very well, thank you."

Adora turned back to look out the window again, seemingly entranced by what, in Kate's opinion, wasn't a great view.

The brunette took the opportunity to study her visitor, who was clad in what appeared to be the same outfit as last night, minus the interesting red jacket she'd been wearing.

She was Kate's height and looked fit, the definition of her arms and shoulders visible through the tight fitting shirt she was wearing.

Before Kate could direct her attention back to her coffee and ask Adora about Etherian breakfast traditions, a soft voice called out, "Adora?"

Both Kate and Adora turned to see Catra standing there, blinking at them sleepily.
But upon taking in the scene, the look transformed into any icy glare directed right at Kate, and the brunette swore that she saw the sudden glint of claws.

It took a second to realize that from Catra's perspective it must have looked like she was blatantly checking Adora out.

And she wasn't really, okay, maybe a little, but in a professional way.
So this was just great. Now everyone thought she was creeping on their partners.

By the time all these thoughts had flashed through her mind, Adora had crossed over to Catra and run a gentle hand through her tousled hair.

Kate pretended to be fascinated by her coffee cup, but snuck a peek and saw that scowl melt from the magicat's face, to be replaced with something much softer.
And then it was like they were the only two in the room.

Behind them, Kate saw Glimmer crossing groggily to the bathroom, her hair a disastrous pink mop.

Edging carefully past the couple who were now in a loose embrace, she made it back into the kitchen, waving at Bow as she

passed.
He was sitting cross-legged on the sofa bed looking at some kind of tablet-like device.

As she poured herself more coffee, Glimmer came back into the room, cutting her eyes over to Adora and Catra and letting out an annoyed scoff.

"Those two are so gross, especially in the morning."

Kate suppressed a smile, and at the moment, Glimmer caught her eye and they shared a conspiratorial look.

Feeling slightly relieved, she asked, "Do Etherians eat pancakes?"

From across the room Adora piped up excitedly, "Did you say cake?"

By the time Yelena returned with Lucky, carrying a backpack that she definitely hadn't had the night before, Kate was in the middle of making a stack of pancakes and a big batch of scrambled eggs. Bow was watching the cooking process with interest while the others loitered about nearby.

Once Lucky's leash was off, he acted like he was going to walk over to Catra, but this time she stood her ground and let out a warning hiss.

Being a smart boy, Lucky thought better of it and instead walked over and sat down in front of his food bowl.

Kate lost track of where Yelena was for a moment, and then suddenly was aware of her presence again right behind her as she asked, "Is there more coffee?"

Hearing the Russian woman's voice so close to her ear made Kate feel suddenly warm, and she gestured towards the coffee maker with her spatula in lieu of a verbal response.

After the ex-assassin had poured herself a cup and downed half of it, she said, “I’m going to change. I will be right back.”

“Yeah, okay. Sounds good.”

Kate was proud of getting those words out, but her tone must have sounded a little odd because Bow gave her a sideways look, though he didn’t say anything.

Glimmer came up to Kate’s side now and peered at the dark liquid sitting in the cup on the counter.

“What is that?”

“It’s called coffee. It’s made from…you know what? Let’s just say it’s a traditional morning beverage in some places on Earth.”

“Can I try it?”

“Uh, sure.”

Glimmer took a big gulp, immediately followed by a disgusted face.
“It’s very bitter.”

“Oh, yeah. Sorry! Some people put cream or sugar in it. I used all the milk for the pancakes, but there’s some sugar somewhere.”

After a quick rummage through her cabinets, Kate found a bag of sugar and grabbed a spoon.

She poured Glimmer a new cup of coffee and said, “Okay, so this is sugar. It’s sweet so it will cut the bitterness. Just put a little in and…”

She trailed off as Glimmer dumped a heaping spoonful of sugar in, followed by a second, and then a third.

“Yeah, that’s…that’s probably enough. Then you stir it.”

The shorter girl followed her directions, agitating the coffee fiercely with the spoon.
She sniffed the cup suspiciously, and then with a shrug, took a cautious sip.

Kate waited for her to spit it out, knowing how ridiculously sweet that sugar to coffee ratio would be, but to her surprise, Glimmer now gave a pleased smile.

"Much better!"

She picked up the cup and wandered over to where Catra and Adora were sitting on the sofa bed and inserted herself into their conversation.

"Are Etherians secretly ants?" Kate mused aloud as she scooped the scrambled eggs into a large bowl.

"What's an ant?" Bow asked.

"Wait, no coffee and no ants?"

Kate was mulling over the easiest way to explain what an ant was when Yelena walked back into the room.

The blond woman had changed into black jeans and a deep red V neck T-shirt and her hair was now up in a neat braid.
Strapped to her leg was some kind of thigh holster and one wrist held a bracelet that Kate knew was actually a widow's bite.

She looked sleek and dangerous and beautiful, and Kate nearly fumbled the stack of plates she was setting on the table.
She tried to play it cool by quickly starting to set the table, with Bow jumping in to assist.

"Perfect timing. The food is ready."

"Food!" Glimmer exclaimed, now firmly in the thrall of a caffeine and sugar high.

“Is there cake now?” Adora asked excitedly.

Thankfully, the Etherians seemed to appreciate the breakfast food, and also seemed to be warming up to their Earth host.

Kate had asked a lot of questions about their planet and their travels in space, which were mostly answered by a friendly Bow, a hyper Glimmer, and an eager Adora.
Catra did contribute, mostly via sarcastic comments, and even managed to make Yelena laugh once.

Kate appreciated that, especially because Yelena was back to her mostly silent watchfulness, and she would much rather have the other woman chill out.

During a lull in the conversation, Kate was wracking her brain for a topic that would engage Yelena without making her feel too vulnerable, when Glimmer suddenly exclaimed, “Oh, I have a question!”

“Oh, yeah, what is it?” Kate asked, distracted.

“Last night you said you were a lezbean and I was wondering what that was.”

Now Glimmer had Kate’s full attention as she tried to figure out how to answer.

“Um…well, for starters, the word is “lesbian”, and it’s…well…”

She could feel Yelena’s eyes on her and was determined not to look at the other woman.

She cleared her throat and tried again.
“A lesbian is a person, specifically a woman who is…attracted to other women. I mean, “woman” is really kind of a limiting word to use but I'm really not qualified to explain gender identity in modern human society so…”.

Kate looked around (not at Yelena) and saw all the Etherians staring at her, still puzzled.

She knew there was no getting out of this, and went on speaking, knowing that her cheeks were turning red.
"What I'm trying to say is that a lesbian is a woman who is romantically and sexually attracted to other women."

She paused again and looked frantically at the Etherians.
"Wait, you do know what sex is, right? Please tell me I don't have to explain that."

"Oh, we know what sex is," Catra drawled.
Next to her, Adora turned as red as a tomato.

At this, Yelena burst out laughing, joined shortly after by Glimmer, and Catra.
Even Kate let out a few relieved chuckles, and next to her, Bow smiled and shook his head.

Then as the brunette stood and started clearing the table, Catra leaned towards Adora and gently rubbed her cheek against her partner's jaw.
"Sorry princess. I didn't mean to embarrass you."

Adora just leaned into the caress and murmured softly, for Catra's ears alone.
"It's just still new, what we have between us. So it feels personal to talk about, I guess."

Catra's tail came to rest against the small of Adora's back and she leaned in to whisper, "I love you dummy."

In an equally soft whisper, Adora replied, "I love you too."

As Catra raised her eyes from Adora's face, she happened to catch the look Yelena was giving Kate while her back was turned.
It was quickly gone, and the woman's face settled back into its normally stony look, but Catra knew what she'd seen, and

recognized that particular type of yearning having gone through it herself.

She filed that information away for the moment, and tried to focus on whatever Glimmer was now yammering about.

It turned out that Glimmer was begging Kate to take them on a tour of the city.
Kate turned to Yelena with a questioning look.

"Are we allowed to do that?"

Yelena sighed deeply, knowing that she'd been instructed by Director Hill to keep everyone sequestered, but finding her will power eroding as those deep blue eyes focused on her.

She replied, grudgingly, "Let me make a phone call."

As she stood up, Kate walked over with the coffee pot, and at Yelena's nod, topped off her cup. The thoughtful gesture pulled a smile out of the blonde and then she quickly walked to the other side of the room with her newly refilled coffee and her phone.

Unbeknownst to her, Kate's eyes followed her progress, and the brunette zoned out as she stared at the Russian woman's fluid movements, so graceful even in the mundane.

By the time Kate realized she was staring, motionless, Bow had come up beside her and was looking at her speculatively.

"Are you okay?"

"Who, me? Yeah, yeah…totally fine."

Bow's face shifted into an understanding smile.
"Listen, I know we just met, but if you want to talk about anything, I'm your guy. I wear a heart on my chest for a reason."

"Thanks Bow," came Kate's grateful response. "I might take you up on that."

“Great. Us archers have to stick together after all.”

When Yelena announced that they had permission to go out, provided they all stayed together and didn't leave Manhattan, Glimmer cheered.

The rest of the Etherians looked somewhere between excited (Adora and Bow) and intrigued (Catra).

“This is going to be so cool,”Kate gushed, “I’ve never been a tour guide for aliens before!”
She directed a smile at Yelena.
“Thank you for making this happen.”

Instead of the expected brush-off, she got an authentic smile in response, which transformed Yelena’s face from the hard lines it was set into something soft and engaging.

“You’re welcome Kate Bishop.”

Chapter End Notes

Yelena was the big spoon.

And maybe there are some feelings...

The Reckoning

Chapter Summary

The Etherians get to see a bit of New York City.

Everyone gets to know each other a little better.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Shoot Your Shot

The Reckoning

It had taken a little work to get the Etherians into outfits that wouldn't draw too much attention, but thankfully since this was New York City, most people wouldn't give a second glance to even the oddest looking fashion ensembles.

Catra's look took the most effort, but with her ears tucked away under a beanie, her arm stripes concealed under a hoodie, and her tail hidden down the leg of a pair of Kate's jeans, she looked passable. Not extremely comfortable, but passable.

Adora was about the same size as Kate, so she was borrowing a t-shirt and a flannel to wear over it, while Bow had switched out his normal top for a long sleeved crop-top he'd had stashed in his bag.

At first, Glimmer refused to change, and with her diminutive stature, Kate knew that any of her clothes would look ridiculous on the pink-haired girl.

Surprisingly, Yelena stepped in and took Glimmer to the other room. When they returned, she was clad in a black t-shirt and gray jeans that fit reasonably well, along with her usual flashy boots.

"Wow, okay. Everyone looks great," Kate said, feeling like a cheesy tour group coordinator.
Waving her arm towards the door intensified this feeling, but she decided to just go with it.

Thankfully, it was a nice, sunny day, with just a tinge of coolness indicating that spring wasn't totally over yet.

Once they were outside, Kate led the way, with the Etherian couples clustering behind her and Yelena trailing slightly behind, constantly on the lookout for danger.

They were impressed by the height of the buildings and the number of people bustling and shoving their way through the streets, though less than impressed with the piles of garbage and the smells of the city.

Kate gave them some brief history of Manhattan and they walked past skyscrapers, high-end shops, corner markets, and busy delis.

After a short period of time wandering through Times Square, which seemed to exhilarate Glimmer but put Catra extremely on edge, Kate led them to the relative quiet of Central Park.

By now Adora and Kate were hungry, so they found a hot dog cart and got to experience the joy of processed meat, most of them for the first time.

Kate had led them to an open spot on the grass where they could sit and people watch as they finished their food cart lunch.

"Is this what everywhere on Earth is like?" Adora asked, after finishing her third hot dog.

Yelena chuckled and replied, "No, thankfully not."

This earned her a glare from Kate, who quickly added, "I know New York City is a lot, but I like how full of life it is. It's the biggest city in this country. But there are lots of other places, very different places."

"So this is where you're from?" Bow asked Kate.

"Yeah, I grew up here. It can be a strange place, but it's home."

The next question, surprisingly, came from Catra, who was sprawled out on the ground in a patch of sun with her head pillowed on Adora's thigh.

“How did the two of you meet?” she asked, looking between the two humans.

At this, Yelena chuckled again, leaning back on her arms and raising an eyebrow at Kate.

“Uhhhh…well…,” the brunette stuttered.

“Oh Kate Bishop, it is a simple tale. I came to the city to kill a man who I thought had killed my sister, and this very annoying girl with a bow got in my way…”

“You mean, you threw me off a roof,” Kate interrupted.

“I attached a safety line first.”

“But I didn’t realize that at the time.”

“Because I am so fast and skilled.”

“If that’s the way you want to spin it,” Kate grumbled.

The Etherians were watching this back and forth banter with interest.

Yelena interrupted Kate with a grin and finished her tale.

“Yes, well, in the end, I did not kill this man and Kate did not shoot me with any arrows, and then later we had a drink together and now we are…”.

“Friends.”

“Acquaintances.”

“Colleagues. Mutually respectful colleagues.”

Yelena rolled her eyes, but did not respond further, allowing Kate to take up the tale.

"Anyway, I hadn't seen Yelena in a few months until she turned up on the trail of your ship. So I guess that you brought us back together."

Bow flashed a smile at both of them.
"Glad we could be of help."

Glimmer seemed to be winding down from her earlier sugar high, but since she was now drinking a large bottle of soda, that was probably about to change.

Catra was still reclining in Adora's lap, and the blonde was gently stroking her cheeks.
As Kate watched, she wondered about the two of them, and how they'd gotten together given their obvious differences in personality (and species).

"How did the two of you meet?" she blurted out, gesturing at Adora and Catra, "I mean, especially given that one of you is a magicat."

Catra's eyes flicked up to Adora's face, and then she said, "We've known each other since we were small. Both of us were kidnapped, or found, or whatever you want to call it, and raised to be Horde soldiers. The Horde was an evil army trying to take over Etheria."

Catra paused as Adora reached down to hold her hand, and then continued, "Obviously, there's a much longer version, but the main points are that Adora defected and became a do-gooder and I stayed behind and basically took over the Horde, but then a bigger bad showed up and kidnapped me and Sparkles…"

Here Glimmer huffed but didn't interrupt.

"And after some pretty epic adventures in space, we made it back to Etheria, fought off the clone army, released the planet's magic, and Adora defeated the big bad once and for all."

In a soft voice, Adora added, "You always forget to mention the part where you saved me from dying with a love confession, and then your kiss brought back my magic avatar powers."

A visible blush rose on Catra's cheeks.
"Yeah, yeah, that happened too," she grumbled, even as she gently squeezed Adora's hand.

"Wow, okay. Oh man, I wish there was time to hear the whole story!" Kate replied, fidgeting excitedly.

"Oh, yeah! There are so many awesome parts!" Glimmer exclaimed, sitting up and gesturing with her hands.
It appeared that her new sugar high was starting to kick in.

"Like when we rescued Catra…or when we found Melog…finally making it back to Etheria and saving our chipped friends…."

Bow smiled at her enthusiasm, and she subsided and leaned against his side.
"But I guess none of that really makes sense without the whole story."

There was a brief silence, which was broken by a quiet question from Yelena.
"So when you were in this Horde army, you were made into child soldiers?"

"They taught us to fight. Trained us to hate and fear the princesses, like Glimmer, and told us that we were the liberators, that we would save the planet. It was all lies," Adora answered.

Her brow furrowed at the memory and Catra let out a sigh and shook her head, adding, "We were trained to be tools, and punished if we disobeyed."

Now Adora's face shifted into a grim expression and one of her hands trailed gently along Catra's face.
"Some of us more than others."

Catra's response was quiet, clearly directed at Adora.
"She's gone. Let it go babe."

A respectful hush fell for a moment, and then Yelena cleared her throat and stated, "I was also trained to be a child soldier. Or, more specifically, a child assassin."

Kate's eyebrows shot up at this admission, and everyone else directed their focus at the Russian woman and she hugged her knees and then continued in a dispassionate tone.

"It was called the Red Room, and we were all girls, either bought or stolen. They trained us to spy, and fight, but mostly to kill. When I was younger they controlled us through pain and fear, but then one of us escaped…my sister…and they began using drugs to control us so we would not remember. You would forget who you were, where you had come from, everything but the job."

"Mind control," Catra spat.

"Yes."

Yelena's hazel eyes met Catra's heterochromic ones for a long, long look.

Whatever they each saw there seemed to foster a mutual understanding, and they both nodded.
For her part, Kate was sitting on her hands to keep her from reaching out to Yelena with a comforting touch.

She was the only one who'd noticed and understood the momentary pause as Yelena had said "my sister", and her heart ached for what the other woman had been through.
But she stayed silent and let Yelena finish her tale.

"Eventually, an antidote to the mind control drug was developed and I was freed. My sister and I reunited and destroyed the Red Room and the man behind it. Since then it has been my mission to free all the others. There were many of us spread out across the globe, but I will find them all."

An impressed and respectful silence fell over the group as she finished her story, and Kate finally gave into her impulses and laid one hand gently on Yelena's arm.

The blonde woman gave her a small, tight smile, but did not pull away, and as Kate's hand started to move in a soothing motion, Yelena's fists gradually unclenched.

Though none of the Etherians commented, both Catra and Bow were watching the interaction between the two humans closely.

They all sat for a few minutes, taking in the park and reflecting on the words that had been spoken.
Kate had just opened her mouth to suggest the next touristy thing they could do when Yelena's phone buzzed.

The Russian woman stood, removing the phone from her pocket and stepping away a short distance to take the call.

The conversation was brief, and she returned to the group, tucking away her phone and standing with her hands folded behind her back.

"It seems that S.H.I.E.L.D. has located the ship and has transported it to a secure location. If you still wish to inspect it, they will send someone to pick us up and take us there."

The Etherians were all scrambling to their feet, and Glimmer was the first one to verbally respond.

"Of course we want to see the ship!"

She looked ready to start running that instant, but didn't know how to get back to Kate's apartment, and was forced to stand waiting expectantly.

"Did they find any other clones?" Adora asked, seeming concerned.

Yelena shook her head.
“The ship was empty and they found no traces of any life forms.”

Glimmer was getting impatient with the delay.
“What are we waiting for? Let’s go!”

Yelena raised an eyebrow at Kate who took the hint and started to lead them back towards her apartment.

Once the whole group was in motion, Yelena sent off a quick text and then dropped back to a rear position, trailing the rest of them by a few steps.

Kate watched her fall to the back and sighed, then turned to face forward again as Glimmer and Bow came up on either side of her like eager bookends.

As was usually the case, Bow was the conversation initiator.

“Yelena seems like a very…capable…person.”

“That’s definitely one way to describe her. She’s also incredibly stubborn and frustrating. And yeah, she has a lot of life experience and a dark and mysterious past, but would it kill her to open up a little more, you know, have a little fun? It’s not that much to ask, right?”

“Huh. Seems like you have a lot of feelings about her,” Bow replied in an innocent tone.

He didn’t miss the amused look that Glimmer gave him.
Kate however, remained oblivious.

“Feelings? What? No, just, observations, that’s all. Totally objective observations.”

Kate kept her mouth shut for a while after that, and didn’t speak again until Glimmer asked her a question.

“So this shield group, what are they about? Can we trust them with the ship?”

“I’d like to think so,” Kate answered slowly. “My mentor at least trusts the current director, who you met last night.”

This seemed to give Glimmer enough assurance for the moment, because she started chattering away about the sights they were passing even as they maintained an extremely quick walking pace.

They stopped in at Kate’s apartment long enough for the Etherians and humans to grab some gear and weapons, and then they hurried back outside and into the large, black SUV that had been sent to pick them up.

After a moment of hesitation about getting into this new form of vehicle, Glimmer and Bow slid into the middle row of seats, followed by Kate, and Catra and Adora piled into the back row trailed by Yelena.

After the Etherians had a few moments to get used to the motion of the vehicle, and Glimmer had sent a sufficient number of suspicious glares at the black-suited driver, a new conversation started.

This one was instigated by Glimmer, who leaned forward over Bow to ask Kate a question.

“Do you have any magic here on Earth?”

“When you say magic, I assume you don’t mean party tricks, right?”

At those words, Glimmer scowled.

Kate quickly back-pedaled.
“Sorry, not trying to be insulting…I just want to clarify. On Earth magic is usually, um, not real. But I’m guessing that’s not the case on Etheria?”

This led to an explanation from Adora and Glimmer, in sometimes overlapping sentences, explaining the magic of their planet and its connection to some kind of superhero avatar, and the people called First Ones.

Kate tried her best to follow what they were saying, but at one point as she craned her neck around to look at Adora, she found herself accidentally looking at Yelena instead, and admiring just how attractive the blonde woman was.

Those hazel eyes suddenly snapped towards her, and it was too late to look away.
Thankfully, Yelena's only response was to send a smirk in Kate's direction.

But, apparently, that brief interaction had caused Kate to lose focus for longer than she realized, because she was suddenly aware that all the Etherians were now looking at her, and Yelena was staring out the window with a blank, innocent expression.

She tried to play it cool, but failed.
"Um…were you just asking me something?"

A disrespectful snickering came from the back seat, but as soon as Kate had turned to glare at the Russian woman, Yelena said, "They asked if you know of any true magic users on Earth, Kate Bishop. And there is at least one in New York City. Dr. Strange the Sorcerer."

"Oh right! I've never met him, but he's one of the Avengers and he practices the mystic arts, which I guess is what you would call true magic."

"Apparently he has a cloak that flies. Which would be very cool to see," Yelena added, to Kate's surprise.

"If there are people on Earth who can access magic, maybe I can too," Glimmer was saying, excitement lacing her tone.

As the pink-haired girl got a look of concentration on her face, Bow looked alarmed.

"Glimmer, maybe don't…"

He was cut off as she simply vanished in a cloud of sparkles.

"Holy shit!" Kate shouted.

In the back seat Yelena looked ready to pull a knife, or a gun, while Adora crossed her arms in resignation and Catra simply rolled her eyes.

Then suddenly, Glimmer was back in her seat, laughing delightedly.

"It works!"

Bow gave her a tentative smile and patted her hand.
"Maybe a little warning next time?"

To his credit, the driver had barely reacted, perhaps because he didn't realize what had happened until the moment had passed.

Kate let out a long breath and tried to get her heart rate to slow down.
It wasn't every day she watched someone vanish and reappear.

Glimmer at least had the decency to look slightly chastened. Before she could say anything though, Catra's voice came from the back of the SUV.

"Glad you had your fun Sparkles, but maybe we should figure out our plan for what to do when we get to the ship?"

As Bow started talking about pods and gesturing to his tracker pad, Kate kind of zoned out of the conversation, muttering to herself, "Are we not going to talk about Glimmer just apparating or whatever?"

None of their space guests seemed to hear her, but as she turned in her seat in an attempt to better follow their conversation, she caught Yelena with an uncharacteristically unguarded expression on her face. Her eyes were unfocused and she looked uncomfortable, almost sad.

But then she caught Kate looking, and the expression smoothed out into something more neutral, though she did give the brunette a small smile before focusing her attention on the scenery passing them by.

Kate was just considering whether to try and ask Yelena if she was alright, when the SUV started to slow down.

They were turning down a side street in an industrial area.
After going through a few gates that required the driver to either enter a code or swipe a key card, they arrived at a large garage door.

As the SUV stopped, conversation inside the vehicle did as well.

There was one stretched out moment of anticipation and then, for the first time in their journey, the driver spoke.
"Director Hill is waiting for you inside."

Chapter End Notes

> Next time: They explore the clone ship, Yelena and Kate have a conversation, and there is pizza!

The Quest

Chapter Summary

Yelena and Kate have a conversation.
The Etherians check out the ship.
Pizza and bonding.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Shoot Your Shot

The Quest

As soon as they'd exited the vehicle, Yelena's whole attitude shifted to a cool and professional detachment.

Kate noted the other woman's features harden and her posture stiffen, and she mourned the loss of the few moments of emotion she'd been privy to.

Her attention was diverted as Director Hill walked up, trailed by a small but heavily armed cadre of guards and a few scientist looking types holding various pieces of equipment.

"Good afternoon. We found this ship not far from your landing site, and we managed to deactivate its cloaking device. But we wanted to wait until you arrived to fully explore the interior."

Now the entire group stared up at the ship looming above them. It was larger than the Etherian's ship, and gleamed under the bright lighting.
At the moment, it seemed inert, with no lights visible from the inside of the craft.

After giving them all a moment to take it in, Director Hill asked the Etherians, "Is there anything you can tell us about this ship? Any hazards we should be aware of?"

The four space guests conferred briefly and then Adora shook her head.
"We don't think so. Though the only ship we were ever on was the main one. And the only hazards there were the clones themselves."

With nothing but a series of nods and some commanding eye contact, the director organized a group to board the ship.

Yelena had remained silent and slightly in the background during all this, but as the Etherians and their escort of S.H.I.E.L.D. agents and scientists started walking towards the ship's open hatch, Kate reached out and gently grabbed Yelena's arm.

The Russian woman pivoted smoothly, turning to glare at her with one eyebrow raised challengingly.

"What are you doing Kate Bishop?"

Kate quickly dropped her arm and managed to mostly not stutter as she responded, "Oh, I just thought we could let them do their thing, check out the ship."

"And what will we be doing in the meantime?"

"We could talk?"

"Talk," Yelena repeated, saying the word as if it tasted bad.

Kate plastered on what she hoped was an encouraging smile. "Yeah, talk. A lot of weird things have happened over the past few days, I never thought I'd meet a magicat or an archer from space…but here we are."

As Yelena continued to give her a stony look, she continued, "So, you know, maybe we could talk about it…like two friends would."

The blonde woman responded in an amused tone, "Do you want to be friends, Kate Bishop?"

Maybe Kate was imagining it, but it sounded like Yelena's voice was even deeper and huskier than usual, and for a moment, she couldn't get any words out.

A glance at Yelena's face showed that, unsurprisingly, the woman was smirking.

Not one to back down from a challenge, even when it came in the form of a gorgeous ex-assassin who made her want to combust,

Kate took a step closer.

"Maybe *friends* doesn't quite describe what I want."

She was gratified to see Yelena's eyes widen, just for a moment, as she struggled to maintain her annoying smirk, but the blonde quickly regained the upper hand as she leaned in and said, practically into Kate's ear, "Maybe one day you can describe to me exactly what you do want."

Kate froze, still as a statue, as Yelena took a step back, folded her hands behind her, and waited for the archer to regain her ability to speak.

After a few long moments of Kate not saying anything, Yelena decided she might as well answer the questions that she assumed Kate was going to ask.

"For the past few months I have been traveling all over the globe, working to free the last widows who were still trapped in chemical subjugation. My mama had been helping by synthesizing more of the antidote that was used to free me, but after a point, she did not have enough resources and materials to make any more."

Yelena's words seemed to free Kate from her paralysis, and she was now listening intently.

"I knew that I could not complete my mission of freeing the final widows without more assistance, so I contacted S.H.I.E.L.D.. Maria Hill agreed to help track down the final widows and provide the resources to create more antidote, but in return, I needed to work for them as an agent."

As she listened, Kate looked more and more impressed.
She'd had no idea what Yelena had been up to, and had assumed that she was still an assassin for hire. Instead, it seemed that she was following in her sister's footsteps.

A vision of herself as the new Hawkeye and Yelena as the new Black Widow flashed through her mind, but she pushed that

thought away for now because she wanted to see if Yelena would talk to her more.

"And have you freed all the widows?"

A small smile graced the ex-assassin's face.
"We are very close. There are only a few more to go, and I am confident that we will complete this mission soon."

"Then what will you do?"

A brief flicker of consternation crossed the blonde's face.

"I am not sure. Likely I will continue to work as a S.H.I.E.L.D. agent, at least for a while."

She paused and continued, in a softer tone, "I am not used to having choices. It can be…overwhelming."

Then, so quietly that Kate almost couldn't make out her words, she added, "I have also been seeing a therapist to try and help me make sense of all my feelings, and deal with my past."

Kate was astounded by this bit of vulnerability, and made sure to keep her voice low and even when she replied, "Therapy helped me out a lot. My mom made me go when I was a kid, after my dad died. And then I actually started going again recently. Everything with my mom, and dealing with the company…plus of course dealing with dangerous mobsters…it was a lot to try and handle on my own."

Yelena gave her a small, grateful smile and nodded.

"Yes, I have found that it is good to have help."

Given this unexpected turn in the conversation, Kate felt a little more comfortable asking her next question.

"On the drive over here, after Glimmer zapped away or whatever, you looked…sad almost? So I wanted to check and see if you

were okay."

Yelena's eyes flicked up and searched Kate's face for a moment, before she looked away and took one deep breath.

Then, in a quiet tone that was full of suppressed emotion, she said, "I was one of the many who disappeared in The Blip. My last memory before I came back was looking down at my hands and watching them vanish. When I came back, for me it was like no time had passed. But the world had moved on, and worst of all, my sister was gone, forever."

Her words trailed off, and she inhaled slowly, as if to steady herself, then looked up and right into Kate's eyes.

"I do not like being reminded of what it feels like to disappear. It reminds me of what I lost."

Unsure of what she could possibly say that would be an adequate response to this confession, Kate stepped forward and folded Yelena gently into her arms.

At first, it was like hugging a plank of wood, but gradually, the other woman relaxed and wrapped her arms around Kate's waist in a solid hold.

They stayed there, floating in a sense of warmth and comfort.

The S.H.I.E.L.D. agents and scientists trailed slightly behind the Etherians as they cautiously made their way up the entry ramp and onto the ship.

Adora was leading the way, with Catra just a step behind, and Glimmer and Bow following along after them.

As they cleared the top of the ramp, lights flicked on soundlessly, and they all tensed, but there was no sound or movement.

With a glance back at her partner, Adora continued forward slowly. This ship was extremely reminiscent of the Velvet Glove in its structure and layout, and they continued down the corridor past open doorways leading into mostly empty rooms.

"This is creepy," Glimmer said, in an almost whisper and Bow nodded vigorously in agreement.
He had his tracker pad out and was keeping a careful eye on the readouts.

As they came even with the next doorway and looked inside, Bow said, "Wait. Stop here."

The four Etherians walked into the room cautiously. It was empty except for some type of control console, though the walls were lined with empty pods, the connectors within hanging loose.

The human scientists had followed them in, and one asked hesitantly , "Do you know what these are?"

Bow answered, trying to be friendly even as he concentrated on the surroundings.
"These are spaces where the clones would be hooked in. We've seen them on other ships."

The scientist nodded gratefully and motioned to her colleagues. They fanned out across the room and started inspecting the room, taking readings of the pods with various instruments and talking quietly amongst themselves.

Meanwhile, Catra was counting the pods in the room, turning to Adora with a frown once she'd finished.
"There are more pods here than clones that we fought."

Her partner nodded.
"Let's make sure there aren't any more of these on the ship. I want to know how many potential clones we're dealing with."

Catra leaned into Adora's side slightly, the only admission she'd make to how spooked this place was making her.

Adora wrapped an arm around her and gave one shoulder a gentle squeeze, but before she could whisper any words of encouragement, Glimmer motioned them over.

"Any idea what this is all about?" she asked, pointing to a large nook in the wall where something appeared to have been recently connected.

Bow was kneeling down to look at some scrapes on the floor. "These look recent, like something heavy was pulled out from the wall."

A couple of the human scientists crossed the room to inspect the space, examining the fitting attached to the wall, taking various readings, and using words that the Etherians were unfamiliar with.

"What are you talking about?" Glimmer finally demanded, "Do you know what was here?"

The same woman from earlier responded, "From what we can tell it was some kind of tank. We would call this something similar to cryo technology…something was being kept frozen, likely something biological. But I'll admit, this technology is unfamiliar to us, so I can't tell you anything definitively."

Now Bow looked troubled and drew his friends away slightly. "The clones were never frozen. And Entrapta and I never saw anything in a tank on Prime's ship."

"Neither did I," Catra added, "but there were lots of rooms I couldn't get into."

"Maybe this has something to do with why the clones came here," Adora said.
"We still don't know what they're doing, and unless we find this tank somewhere on the ship, that means the clones took it with them onto Earth."

The four Etherians exchanged concerned looks.

“Let’s look at the rest of the ship and then we can figure out what to do next.”

The other three nodded at Glimmer’s suggestion, and then they made their way out of the room and back into the corridor, hoping that they would come across some answers instead of additional questions.

Unfortunately, the ship did not yield any clues as to what the clones were up to or where they might have gone.

A careful count of all the wall pods led them to estimate that there were at least ten clones unaccounted for, possibly more depending on how many had been flying the ship and therefore not plugged in.

During their debrief, Director Hill had said that there were still no sightings of any clones either by S.H.I.E.L.D. or reported by civilians.

“Considering how easy they are to spot, we have to conclude that they’re either hiding in a building and staying there, or that they’ve gone underground. And I do mean that literally.”

“Underground?” Adora asked, looking thoughtful.
“On Etheria, there were secret spaces underground where ancient technology was hidden. Maybe Prime did the same thing on Earth?”

“You’re suggesting that Earth was visited by this Prime?”

“He said he was the ruler of the entire galaxy,” Adora replied with a shrug.
Then her voice shifted into something more distant, with a tinge of power at the edges.
“His consciousness was old and he traveled far, satisfied only by continued conquest.”

At those words, Director Hill raised an eyebrow, and Catra took Adora's hand, squeezing gently.
In response to the touch, Adora blinked several times, and seemed to come back to herself.

After a moment, the director said,
"We will continue to search for the remaining clones, as well as whatever they brought off this ship. Now that we know they took something, we might be better able to track them."

Having said that, the director turned to Kate, who had been lingering behind the Etherians with Yelena standing beside her.

"Ms. Bishop. Will you be able to continue to host our guests until we track down the remaining hostiles?"

Trying to contain her excitement, Kate shifted from foot to foot. "Absolutely! Not a problem at all. Assuming of course that they want to stay with me?"

She turned to the Etherians who all looked relieved at her offer, and Glimmer was the one to answer for them.

"We'd like to stay with Kate. We aren't leaving Earth until we figure out what the clones are up to and take them out."

Director Hill nodded, seemingly unsurprised by this answer.

"Very well. Agent Belova will continue to stay with you. I'll be in touch as soon as we have an update."

At that, she made a gesture, and an escort stepped up to guide the party of six back to their ride, which was the same SUV that had brought them to the hangar.

The trip back to Kate's apartment was conducted mostly in silence.

Yelena seemed to have retreated back into her protective shell, barely acknowledging any conversation that was happening.

Catra and Adora seemed to be having their own silent conversation composed entirely of looks and gentle touches, while Glimmer was looking out the window distractedly, repeatedly clenching and unclenching her fists.

Bow was the only one who seemed willing or able to string more than a few words together, so Kate was able to get a summary of what they'd discovered on the ship.

Despite the Etherian's concern, she wasn't feeling all that worried. After all, they had the resources of S.H.I.E.L.D. and their combined team of six, which she personally thought was a pretty impressive little force.

Surely they'd be able to take down a dozen or so of the clones and get back whatever weird, secret tank they were hiding.

If her somewhat inappropriate good mood had anything to do with the talk she'd had with Yelena and the subsequent best hug of her life, she wasn't ready to admit it.

Once they got back to Kate's apartment, Yelena took Lucky and left again with only a brief word of goodbye.

Kate's eyes stared at the door for a while after it closed, long enough for Bow to gently nudge her arm and ask if she was okay.

"Yeah. I'm all good."

She looked around the room and stood up a little straighter.

"I bet everyone is hungry, and I'm pretty confident that none of you has ever had pizza before."

At the blank looks she was getting, she assumed she was correct.

"Okay, this is exciting. I get to introduce you to my favorite food!"

Her enthusiasm was at least a little infectious, because Glimmer perked up, and Adora and Bow looked genuinely excited.

Kate pulled out her phone and stepped away, already running through how many different pizza combinations she could reasonably order.

Yelena was quite thankful that walking Lucky gave her a good excuse to leave the apartment.
It had taken her a while to settle her feelings after the earlier vulnerability she'd displayed to Kate, but after some fresh air and movement, she was feeling much more centered.

When she walked back through the door of Kate's apartment, the brunette was fiddling with a tall stack of pizza boxes.

At the smell of his favorite food, Lucky started manically bouncing around and trying to run into the kitchen.

Yelena managed to remove his leash before he got totally tangled, but then he made an aggressive beeline for Kate who thankfully managed to set down the boxes she was holding before her dog slammed right into her legs.

Unfortunately though, she wasn't able to catch herself, and she started to fall.
She braced herself for impact and involuntarily closed her eyes.

The expected impact never came however, and her eyes flew open as she tried to figure out what was happening.
It turned out that she was being cradled tightly in Yelena's strong arms, the blonde woman having somehow made it over in time to catch her.

The position had left their faces very close together, and Kate quickly found herself getting lost in Yelena's eyes, which were full of flecks of color that she'd never noticed before.

It was unclear how long they stayed like that, frozen in the moment, but they were ultimately brought out of it when Glimmer stepped out of the bathroom, took in the scene, and asked, loudly, "Did I miss something?"

In a move that would have made a professional dancer envious, Yelena slid Kate into an upright position and twirled away, ending up on the other side of the kitchen almost before the brunette could blink.

The rest of the Etherians were staring from the other side of the room, all of them having started moving when they saw Kate trip even though they were too far away to do anything to help.

"Uh, good catch?" Bow finally offered, his voice squeaking a little when Yelena whipped her head around to glare at him.

Catra and Adora were sharing a look that no one else could translate, so Bow started walking towards the food, grabbing Glimmer by the arm as he went.

"So, tell me about this pizza you were so excited about."

Bow's friendly inquiry and Lucky's adorable whine when he heard the word "pizza" finally snapped Kate out of her reverie.

She enthusiastically gave the Etherians a mini-lecture on pizza and showed off all the various combinations of toppings that she'd ordered.

If her face was a little flushed and she was unable to make eye contact with Yelena for at least 20 minutes, her guests were too polite to mention it.

But as Kate devoured her pizza, she couldn't help but think about how it felt to be cradled in Yelena's arms, and how, while she was, she could feel Yelena's heart beating faster than normal.

An astonishing amount of pizza had been consumed, and the group was sprawled around the living room having a lively conversation about Etherian cuisine.

Or, more accurately, Catra was perched on the arm of the couch next to Adora, who was leaning against her, while Bow and Glimmer were wrapped up in a snuggly pile on the floor.

Kate was standing across from them with one elbow propped against the counter while she absently petted Lucky, and Yelena was sitting rather rigidly in a chair nearby.

There was a lull in the conversation, and then Bow asked Kate, "Any chance of you showing me some of your trick arrows?"

Immediately, Kate's eyes lit up.

"Oh absolutely! I have a whole workshop in the basement. There's even a few arrows we can try out down there without damaging anything."

Bow gently disentangled himself from a sleepy looking Glimmer and walked over to Kate with an excited smile.

The two of them walked out the apartment door, chattering away, and then Kate led Bow down the hallway and to the private staircase she used for basement access.

It turned out that Kate had never experienced the full power of Bow's enthusiasm until the moment that he gazed upon the splendor of her workshop.

She showed him her expansive set of tools, the racks of gleaming arrows, and even opened up a locked safe to let him ogle some of her most dangerous trick arrowheads.

Honestly, she'd been a little astonished when Clint had hooked her up with one of "his guys", but she hadn't blown up any parked cars recently, so she figured she'd earned a little grace.

This connection had helped her get parts and tech for a whole array of trick arrows, most of which she'd never tested in the field, but would just admire lovingly from time to time as they sat waiting in her workshop.

Bow was the perfect audience to geek out with.

"So wait, you're telling me that this arrow will shrink things? That's amazing!" he had exclaimed at one point.

"It really is! Just don't ask me to explain how the science works, because I truly have no clue."

They spent some time shooting regular arrows at the various targets placed throughout the basement, and when they were tired of that, Kate went over to one of the racks and picked up an arrow with a small purple "B" painted on the side of the arrowhead.

"Okay, now stand over there and watch this."

Once Bow was safely standing about 6 feet away, Kate carefully aimed the arrow at the far corner of the basement and released it. When it hit the wall, it rebounded off, and headed right back at Kate.

Bow yelped, startled, but Kate reached out and grabbed it out of midair with one hand.

As she turned to him with a wide grin, he started cheering.

"Whoa…what's that arrow called?"

Kate twirled it in her fingers for a moment, and then responded, "Well, I really want it to be a boomerang arrow, but at the moment, it doesn't come back until it hits something…so technically I have to call it ricochet arrow."

Once they'd collected all the stray arrows and put everything away again, Kate said, "I think I'm going to stay down here for a

bit and get some more training in. Are you okay to get back upstairs by yourself?”

“Sure! I can’t wait to tell Glimmer about all this cool stuff.”

Once he was gone, Kate pulled off her hoodie, leaving her in just a dark purple sports bra.

Then she moved over to the other side of the basement, where a decent amount of workout equipment, including a rack of dumbbells and barbells, sat waiting for her.

After several rounds of pushups, bicep curls, shoulder presses, and pullups, she stood for a moment, wiping sweat off her forehead with the back of her wrist.

As she lowered her arm, she caught someone’s reflection in the mirror next to her and whirled, nearly jumping out of her skin as she saw Yelena standing there, silent and staring.

“Yelena! Jesus! You scared the shit out of me!”

Even at this exclamation, the blonde still did not speak.

Instead, her hazel eyes were roaming across Kate’s sweaty, exposed skin and tracing the muscles that were still popping after the circuit she’d put them through.

The archer suddenly clocked that heated gaze and opened her mouth, then closed it again.

If it had been anyone else looking at her like that, Kate might have said something flirtatious.
And if they hadn’t been in a basement with a group of friendly aliens upstairs, she might have even made a move.

But all she could do was stand and be devoured by those eyes.

Eventually, Yelena seemed to realize what she was doing and her eyes darted away as she fixed her gaze on the wall instead.

“Kate Bishop,” she said, in a tone that poorly hid how flustered she was, “I was just coming to check on you.”

Barely able to form words as her mouth suddenly felt incredibly dry, Kate squeaked out, “I’m good. Yeah, all good here. Let’s, uh, let’s go back upstairs.”

Yelena just nodded stiffly and started to march away.
After a moment, Kate followed after, head whirling with possibilities.

Back upstairs, Yelena seemed determined to look anywhere but at Kate, which did not escape the notice of either Catra or Kate herself.

Picking up on the scrutiny made Kate feel self-conscious, so her attempts to participate in conversation fell flat.

It wasn’t long before she announced that she was going to take a shower and head to bed.
Once she had left the room, the group conversation fragmented into two quiet conversations between the Etherian couples.

Yelena got up out of the chair and headed into the kitchen to clean up, trying in vain to banish images of Kate with no shirt on.

She was so focused on scrubbing off the countertop and sink that she didn’t hear someone come up behind her.

“You don’t have to do that,” came Kate’s voice from behind her, accompanied by the fresh, minty smell of her body wash.

The blonde’s only response was a small, non-committal sound.

“Okay, well I’m going to go to bed. Don’t be stubborn and stay up all night or try sleeping on the concrete floor, okay?”

Yelena nodded, shoulders tensing as she heard Kate sigh lightly and, after a brief pause, walk away.

After a chorus of "goodnights" from the Etherians, she could hear the archer's light footsteps going up the stairs, followed by the patter of Lucky's paws.

A couple hours later, Yelena was alone with a glass and a bottle of vodka, sprawled out in an old chair near the wall of windows.

She'd just taken another sip when a sound caught her ear. Turning her head, she saw the bedroom door open and Catra quietly slipped out, closing the door behind her almost soundlessly.

The magicat approached, seeming unsurprised to see Yelena sitting there.

"Couldn't sleep?" the blonde asked.

"It's very noisy here," Catra responded, even as one of her ears twitched at a chorus of honking horns.

She hopped up onto the window sill and perched there, then looked back over at Yelena.
"What about you? Something on your mind?"

After a moment of consideration, Yelena softly cleared her throat and said, "Sometimes all the things I have done press down on me until it feels hard to breathe."

Having made this admission, Yelena looked down, absently playing with the rings on her fingers.

Heterochromatic eyes regarded the bowed blonde head before her, and then Catra spoke, her voice taking on the timbre of someone telling a difficult story.

“I've done a lot of bad things. Some were out of spite. I was mad because Adora left me behind and I wanted to prove to her that I didn’t need her. Which was a lie of course. And some were because I wanted to destroy the woman who’d been so cruel to me, but to do that I also had to become cruel.”

Catra’s eyes flicked out to the busy street below them for a long moment before she continued.
“But the worst thing I did was almost destroy the world, all because I thought that the person I loved didn’t love me back.”

Yelena’s eyes were fixed on Catra now as the magicat finished her story.

“I didn’t succeed though, because other people were brave. Including Glimmer’s mother, who sacrificed herself to stop what was happening and save everyone. And yet, after all of that people still love me. It was hard to give them a chance to do that, but I did. I tried to do better, and I kept trying. I think in the end, that’s what matters.”

She stopped and let the silence settle as she wiped a few tears from her cheeks.

Then, she looked right into Yelena’s eyes and said, “Don’t use your past as an excuse to push people away. If you have a chance at love, take it.”

With that, she hopped down from her perch, and headed back to the bedroom, leaving a contemplative silence behind.

Chapter End Notes

> This chapter ended up a bit longer than I anticipated, but I wanted to get as much in as possible so the next chapter can be the final one.
>
> We got flirting, we got ogling, we got impure thoughts...what's next? Kissing? 😉

Thanks for reading and commenting.
I'll be back with the final chapter as soon as I get it written!


Endgame

Chapter Summary

There was only one bed.
The clone’s plan is revealed.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Shoot Your Shot

Endgame

The next morning, Kate drifted slowly into consciousness, coming out of a hectic, fading dream and into a sense of safety and peace.

It seemed that Yelena had again snuggled up to her while they were sleeping, and this time, one of the Russian woman's hands was resting lightly against Kate's hip.

Kate lay still and attempted to memorize the feeling, from the places where their skin was touching to the soft tickle of Yelena's breath against the back of her neck.

She wished that they could share this kind of moment of intimacy while they were both awake, but perhaps that was asking too much.

As she tried to formulate a plan to extricate herself without waking Yelena, though truthfully, all she wanted to do was stay here forever, the other woman's low, sleep-roughened voice startled her by saying, "I can feel how hard you are thinking Kate Bishop. It is very distracting."

A pleasurable shiver went down the brunette's spine as Yelena's lips brushed lightly against the back of her neck as she spoke. Because apparently the woman was snuggled that close to her.

Kate was 50% sure that she was still dreaming, especially when the hand on her hip slipped down to rest against her stomach.

That almost made her shiver again, and part of her was certain that if she didn't stay absolutely still, Yelena would vanish.

Without changing her position, she said, in a sleepy but still teasing tone, "Oh, I'm so sorry to be distracting. Good morning by the way."

"Good morning little hawk."

Kate huffed indignantly even as, internally, she swooned at both the nickname and the tone of voice it was delivered in.

"You know…I *am* actually bigger than you."

"Do you really think size matters, Kate Bishop?"

Whatever suggestive rejoinder that Kate was about to make, and she definitely had a few options in mind, was cut off by Yelena's phone ringing.

With an adorable grumble, the blonde woman rolled away and picked up her phone, walking to the other side of the room to answer it.

Kate's brain was still in a fuzzy, warm space, so she didn't pay too much attention to Yelena's end of the phone call, but once the blonde woman had ended the call, she walked back over to sit on the edge of the bed.

"That was S.H.I.E.L.D. They have made a discovery that will perhaps lead to the clones. Once the area has been secured, they want all of us there to investigate."

This information made Kate pop out of bed and start rummaging around for her suit and the gear she wanted to bring.

Yelena's eyes followed her progress around the room, seemingly lost in her own thoughts.
It wasn't until Kate was in the bathroom that Yelena let out a long sigh, stared at the closed bathroom door for a moment, and started dressing in her tactical suit.

It turned out that the unique energy signature of whatever the clones had in their mysterious tank had ultimately led their pursuers to an old two-story office building that seemed to be abandoned.

There was a fence around it, but the rusty chain and broken padlock hanging from the gate weren't providing much of a deterrent to anyone wanting to access the property.

By the time Team Eartheria (a nickname Bow had created that morning) arrived at the scene, a collection of black SUVs and vans were parked outside the gate, and various S.H.I.E.L.D. agents and scientists were milling around outside the building, or forming a perimeter.

Yelena was called over to speak with Director Hill, while Kate stayed with her space guests.

The four of them were taking in the scene, Glimmer with her normal level of suspicion, and Catra with a wary look in her eyes as her tail lashed behind her several times.

"Are you all doing okay?" Kate asked.

"Just ready to get this over with," Catra said, her voice rougher than usual.

Adora rested a hand on her partner's shoulder and had a more serious expression on her face than usual.
"I think we just want to finish this."

"Whatever *this* is," Glimmer muttered. "We still don't know what these clones are up to, but I'm ready to take them down."

Her hand clenched more tightly around her staff, and she looked like she was about to start punching things at any moment.

Bow spared her a concerned look, but his attention was mostly focused on his tracker pad.

Kate wasn't sure exactly what he was doing with it, but he was nodding to himself as if something was making sense.

Seeing this, Glimmer moved closer to him.

"Bow? Did you find something?"

"There are definitely clones here. Now that we're close enough, I can pick up on their energy signature. There's some kind of interference though, so I can't tell much more than that."

Kate absently started checking over her gear, making sure the retractable sword was in place and her quiver was properly secured.

Her eyes drifted over to where Yelena was standing with Director Hill and several other figures dressed in black uniforms.

As if sensing her gaze, Yelena's eyes flicked over and met Kate's, sending a small swooping sensation to the vicinity of the brunette's stomach.

Maybe the blonde was also feeling something too, because she seemed distracted for a moment before getting pulled back into the conversation.

Kate filed that bit of information away, a fizzy sense of hope that had nothing to do with their current mission filling her body.

Eventually, Director Hill walked over, trailed by Yelena and the other agents, she did her best to wipe the smile off her face and stand attentively.

"Good morning. We've traced the clones to this building, and based on the blueprints we obtained, it does have access to some old tunnels. The main two floors have been secured and there's no sign of anything unusual so far, so they must have gone underground."

“No sign of the mysterious tank either?” Kate asked, when the Etherians remained silent.

The Director shook her head.
“Nothing. No alien gear and nothing out of place.”

“Why would they come all this way to hide underground?” Adora asked, mostly to herself.

Bow frowned.
“None of this makes any sense. But there must be some reason.”

“Well, what are we waiting for?” Glimmer chimed in, loudly.
“Let’s go take these guys out, destroy their tank of whatever, and go home!”

This brought a faint, appreciative smile to Yelena’s face, though Director Hill seemed unmoved, even slightly troubled.

“I don’t like going in blind, but I suppose we have no choice. I have a team ready to accompany you, and they’ll be in audio and video contact with myself and the support personnel up here the entire time.”

A few efficient minutes later, the team of S.H.I.E.L.D. agents, armed with a variety of weapons, were doing a communications check.
Yelena had also been issued her own set of comms, and after verifying that they were functioning properly, she’d come to stand near Kate.

The archer looked pleased at this development, and nudged Yelena with her elbow.

“Nervous about this fight?” she asked, flashing a teasing smile at the blonde.

Her smile widened when Yelerna seemed flustered at the attention.

But, her responding dry tone didn't reflect that as she said, "Kate Bishop, these clones are weak and I am not. What is there to be nervous about?"

Though, a moment later, she certainly seemed nervous as Kate took a step closer and laid a hand on her bicep, squeezing gently.

"Yes, you are very strong."

Yelena's eyes widened comically even as she tried not to react.

From nearby, there was a snort of laughter, but when the two women turned to look, the Etherians were all looking in different directions with innocent expressions on their faces.

Director Hill chose that moment to capture their attention.

"Communication channels are open and support personnel are standing by."

The Etherians exchanged glances and then stepped forward to form a line just behind Kate and Yelena.
"Let's do this," Glimmer said decisively, her jaw set in a hard line.

At Director Hill's nod, they were off.

At first, everything seemed unexceptional, almost like they were mistakenly in the wrong location.

The inside of the building looked almost alarmingly mundane. Industrial carpet, dusty cubicles, and flat gray paint. There was no sign of anything unusual.

They made their way to the basement, and again, nothing seemed out of place.
At one end, several floodlights were set up, with a small group of agents waiting nearby.

Their focus was a metal door that led to a set of utility tunnels under the building.

The team made their way through the door and through the low, narrow tunnel full of wiring and pipes. It didn't take long before they got to the end and were facing a concrete wall that marked the edge of the foundation.

This would have been entirely unremarkable if not for a ragged hole in the ground.
Dirt, rock, and chunks of concrete were piled around it, and when the agents in the lead shined their lights into it, they caught the rungs of a metal ladder that had been hung over the edge.

The hole wasn't particularly deep, and the beams of light easily reached the bottom, but all that could be seen was uneven ground and more debris that had presumably fallen through.

With a minimum of words exchanged, the entire group carefully climbed down the ladder and congregated in the space at the bottom, trying not to trip over each other or the debris piled around haphazardly.

Yelena spent some time crouched down and looking at a muddle of footprints in the dust, and when she stood up she asked, "Has anyone else been down here yet?"

With a concerned look, the agent in charge shook her head no.

"These tracks were not all made by clones, unless they are wearing a variety of types of human shoes in various sizes."

That pronouncement ratcheted the anxiety level in the pit a notch higher.
After conferring over comms with the Director, it was decided that they would go forward as planned.

Despite several protests from Team Eartheria, the S.H.I.E.L.D. agents went first, guns drawn and lights attached to their helmets.

The pit opened up into a tunnel wide enough for two people to walk through shoulder to shoulder. They proceeded cautiously for a very short distance and then the whole procession came to a sudden halt.

Because the roughly carved dirt tunnel had opened up into a wider passageway that while ancient looking, was obviously constructed and not naturally occurring. The walls shone with a dull gray gleam, and the edges were as sharp and clean as if they'd been excised with lasers.

It was obviously alien and indisputably creepy, especially as the air seemed to glow with pale green light that had no readily apparent source.

"What the fuck?" Kate whispered to herself, not realizing that she'd spoken out loud until the Etherians and Yelena were all giving her questioning looks.

While Yelena seemed amused, and three of the Etherians just looked puzzled, Glimmer mostly looked interested.

"I like the sound of that word," she said. "What does it mean?"

"Uhhhhh….".

Kate was caught off guard, and wasn't sure that she should teach an alien to curse, but it seemed that Yelena had no such qualms.

In fact, she seemed oddly enthusiastic about explaining.

"This is a very good English word. It can have many different meanings that are good or bad depending on the context, but really it is a word that is talking about sex."

Glimmer seemed unimpressed.
"Oh, it just means sex?"

Yelena's brow furrowed and she tried to explain further.
"It is yes, but also it is more like the act of sex, like an aggressive

description?”

She started to make some very crude and interesting looking hand gestures to try and drive her point home.
“You know. Fucking.”

At that, Adora looked like she was trying to hold in a laugh, Catra grinned savagely, Bow blushed, and Glimmer looked delighted as she pronounced, with relish, “Fuck.”

Kate just gave Yelena a look and muttered, “That’s not what it looks like when I have sex.”

Caught off guard by the comment, the blonde visibly flushed.

This did not escape the notice of the brunette, but Kate did not get a chance to say something that would have undoubtedly gotten her in trouble, because a pointedly cleared throat caused all six of them to spin around and face the agent in charge.

She showed remarkable restraint in not verbally reprimanding them, though Yelena did get a pointed look.

Somewhat humbled, Team Eartheria focused up and started carefully moving through the tunnel again. Unfortunately, their surroundings were not getting any less unsettling, because the walls now had embedded pieces of ancient tech within them at regularly spaced intervals. And this tech seemed to be active based on the low thrumming emanating from it.

Catra’s ears were swiveled forward and her tail puffed up slightly as she stopped dead, nearly causing Adora to stumble.

“Catra? What is it?”

When Catra responded, her voice was higher-pitched than usual.

“Sparkles, do you smell that?”

Glimmer inhaled carefully several times and then she also froze. "It smells like…like…"

"Prime's ship," Catra finished, flatly.

Adora's posture noticeably stiffened and she moved even closer to her partner until their shoulders lightly touched.

They continued onward, more and more tense with each step.

The walk led them farther underground than Kate thought should be possible, the surroundings becoming more alien the farther they went.

It was almost anti-climactic when they finally emerged from the oppressive green glow and supernaturally shining walls into a large chamber full of metal pillars, massive cables, and blinking panels of unfamiliar tech.

At least, it was unfamiliar to the humans. The four Etherians looked truly dismayed as they took in their surroundings. Catra's claws were out and Glimmer was clenching her staff tightly.

Adora manifested a sword from…somewhere, Kate had no idea how she'd done it, but seeing that weapon made Kate draw her bow and fit an arrow to the string.

The S.H.I.E.L.D. agents fanned out slightly, slowing their pace to a cautious prowl as they moved across the chamber and through a large archway at the other end.

As the Etherians started to walk through it, Catra's ears swiveled around quickly and she hissed, "There's something moving in the next room."

The group moved forward even more tensely and everyone stopped dead when the contents of the next room came into view.

Here too, there were pillars and alien tech, but along one wall there were also pods like the ones on the clone ship, all empty. At the far end of the room was a tank, emitting a pale glow. Inside, a pale, somewhat withered form could be seen. It was currently motionless, but the sight of it was enough to make more than one of the Etherians gasp and Catra practically snarl.

"I guess we know what was in the tank," Bow said, in a quiet, hollow voice.

Glimmer spoke next, through a tightly clenched jaw, "Let's destroy it. Now."

But before she could take more than two steps towards the tank, shadowy forms began to emerge from a dark corridor on the other side of the room.

First, it was just clones, marching in orderly lines. But then, other figures began to appear, interspersed amongst the identical white clones. They were humans in a variety of different outfits, with blank expressions and eyes that glowed a pale, sickly green.

"No," Catra murmured, "no, no this isn't possible."

Kate looked at her with concern, and then to Adora, whose face had paled.

Of the four Etherians, only Glimmer didn't seem utterly taken aback. Instead, she just looked pissed and ready to break something.

When she turned to Yelena, Kate saw that her jaw was set and she had a scary looking baton in her hand.
"Shit," Kate muttered to herself.

For a very brief moment, Glimmer's eyes flicked over, and Kate was sure that in a less fraught moment, the shorter girl would be demanding to learn more curse words.

Before anyone could take further action, there was a harsh scraping sound that immediately drew everyone's attention. Several clones near the tank were pulling what looked like a thick white hose out from the wall. With a high-pitched whining sound, it lit up, with a green light that was almost too bright to look at.

Multiple people started yelling in overlapping warnings, and Kate briefly considered launching her arrow before she was grabbed from the side by a fast-moving blonde and forced down into a crouch.

She had a moment to register and appreciate the strength of Yelena's arm around her before the room lit up in a blinding flash with a sound that made her eardrums vibrate painfully.

Then the light was gone and she looked up to see the Etherians gathered behind Glimmer who had her arms outstretched as she… conjured a shield made of pink light?

Kate scrambled to her feet, keeping one hand on Yelena's shoulder as she stared in wonder at the sight before her.

With a gasp, Glimmer dropped her arms and the shield vanished in a cloud of pink and purple sparkles.

Bow was immediately by her side, supporting her as she caught her breath, but thankfully, she seemed to be alright.

"Thanks Glimmer," Adora said, and then Glimmer was stammering out a response, "It was just instinct…I didn't even know if I could do that here, but…".

She was cut off by a harsh exclamation from Yelena, "Pizdets."

Everyone looked at her, and found that her eyes were taking in the S.H.I.E.L.D. agents who had been scattered across the floor by whatever weapon the clones had used. None of them had been positioned to be protected by Glimmer's magical intervention.

But now, they were slowly getting to their feet and each of them had a chillingly blank expression and a pair of glowing green eyes.

From beside Kate, Yelena was letting out a long stream of what seemed to be Russian curse words while Bow fitted an arrow to his bowstring and looked over his shoulder at them.

“Kate! What do we do?”

The brunette was staring at the green eyed agents who were beginning to line up in a formation with all the others.

“We can’t hurt the humans!” she shouted.

“At least not too badly,” Yelena added, grimly.

Ignoring that comment, Kate looked around the room, calculating angles, and then pulled a new arrow from her quiver.

“Bow! As soon as I clear a path, you and Glimmer go take out the clones up there! The rest of us will go for the main group.”

“Kate Bishop, how are you going to….”

Ignoring that question, Kate let the arrow fly and three of the agents closest to them were quickly tangled in a web of metal cables that they struggled against in vain.

“Go!” she shouted, and thankfully Bow and Glimmer took off towards the group of clones by the tank.

Before the others could react, Kate charged forward, and dropped to one knee, letting loose another arrow in one smooth motion.

It embedded in the pillar nearest to the other agents, and with a bright blue flash, engaged a strong magnetic field that ripped the guns right out of their hands.

“Yes!” Kate shouted, throwing one fist in the air.
She turned her head to steal a look at the blonde woman’s face and swore she saw an impressed expression.

While that definitely gave her a thrill, she had only a few seconds to enjoy it before the now unarmed agents began to converge on her.
She tripped the first one with her bow, and dodged a punch from a second, before the next two suddenly dropped, having suffered direct shots from Yelena’s widow bites.

“Thanks,” Kate gasped out.

The blonde nodded at her then turned to shout to Adora and Catra.

“We will take care of the humans. You focus on the clones.”

Their divide and conquer method worked well at first. Kate used a variety of non-lethal arrows to take down the humans amongst the clone army, while Yelena went through them like a whirlwind using her widow bites, stun baton, and a series of moves almost too fast to follow.

Kate nearly got punched in the throat watching the other woman perform the signature black widow move to throw a man twice her size.

As if Yelena could sense the attention, she called out, “Focus Kate Bishop.”

Kate’s response was to sink an arrow straight through the neck of a clone rushing up behind the Russian woman.

One of Yelena’s eyebrows shot up and she gave the archer an over the shoulder look, complete with a small smirk.
Kate got only a brief moment to appreciate that attention before the next wave of combatants came surging forward.

Bow and Glimmer had taken out the clones that had been gathered around the tank, and Bow had used several arrows on any additional clones that had tried to surround them.
Luckily for him, Kate had re-supplied him with some of her own trick arrows, so while he was already running low, he wasn't out just yet.

Glimmer had been gleefully bashing the crap out of any clones who dared get close enough, and was now catching her breath and guarding Bow as he examined the tech surrounding the tank more closely.

Catra and Adora had fought with a synchronicity that came from their years of training together, handling everyone in their path.

By now, the humans were almost all either unconscious or subdued by a variety of ropes, nets, and cables, courtesy of the trick arrows.

One more cluster remained, and as they moved in Kate's direction, she shot a final arrow into the floor right next to them. Upon impact, a series of tiny needles flew out, quickly rendering all the targets unconscious.

For the moment, the fight was over. Kate lowered her bow and walked over to Yelena, who was carefully prodding a few motionless figures with the toe of her boot.

At the brunette's approach, she looked up, with a small smile, and said, "Nice work Kate Bishop."
It was strange that hearing Yelena say those simple words somehow had more meaning than the louder and more excited praise she'd received from coaches and teammates, or the applause from the crowd as she hit another bullseye in competition.

Kate's answering smile was broad.
"You too. One day you have to show me that move, you know..that widow flip."

This request made Yelena enthusiastic.
“This is a very cool move, yes. It requires the right amount of momentum.”
Then she paused, and her smile turned wicked.
“And I would need to put my thighs around your neck.”

At that, Kate gulped, or possibly said the word “gulp” out loud, which would be truly embarrassing.
However, before she could figure out what was happening, Catra and Adora joined them, followed a brief moment later by Glimmer.

“Is everyone alright?” Glimmer asked.
Then, before anyone had a chance to actually respond, she continued, “Bow thinks he found some kind of control panel, so he’s trying to figure out what the clones were trying to do and shut it down.”

Yelena looked towards where Bow was examining a blinking display and her eyes narrowed.
She opened her mouth to speak, but Catra cut her off.

“I think there’s more clones coming.”

Everyone’s eyes immediately darted to the corridor across from them, and they watched in dismay as an even larger group of clones marched out, stopping just inside the room and waiting.

Kate reached into her quiver and found that she had only a few arrows left.

The clones watched them, eyes glowing green, and faces eerily impassive.

“What are they waiting for?” Adora whispered.

Her question was answered by a frantic shout from Bow.

“Guys! Something is happening!”

The tech around the room started to glow brighter, and then the light started to pulse in a slow pattern. The tank started to hum, an irritating low pitched-resonation that echoed through the chamber.

Bow was now moving quickly, as he attempted to find a way to stop whatever was happening. His efforts seemed to be unsuccessful though as the lights and sounds only intensified. The ground in the chamber itself started to rumble.

"This really isn't good. Zero out of ten stars, would not recommend," Kate muttered, her fingers nervously drumming against her leg.

Yelena shot her an arch look, which the brunette found strangely comforting.
If she was going to die in a creepy underground cavern built by aliens, at least the blonde woman would be with her. Maybe it was morbid, but somehow it felt right.

As the rumbling intensified, the clones started to move, marching forward with ill-intent.

Kate quickly drew her final trick arrow and loosed it, not at the clones directly, but into the wall directly above the corridor they were still emerging from. It exploded with an impressive blast, sending a portion of wall crashing down on the clones underneath, and effectively blocking the passageway.

Unfortunately, this did nothing to slow the pace of the group of clones now approaching.

Over the humming and rumbling Glimmer shouted, voice straining, "This might be a good time for She-Ra!"

Adora looked at her and said, "I don't know if I can Glimmer!"

From the other end of the chambers, there was a loud crackling, and when they turned to look, the previously motionless form within the tank began to twitch.

Catra grabbed her partner's hand.
"Please Adora. I know you can do this."

Kate watched as Adora's expression shifted into a grim stubbornness.
The taller blonde stepped back, raised her sword over her head, and shouted, "For the Honor of Grayskull!"

Whatever Kate expected to happen in response, it certainly wasn't an extremely bright glow of sparkling rainbow that enveloped the Etherian. Adora could still be seen within it, but she seemed to be stretching out, getting taller and changing form.

Glimmer was laughing joyfully and Catra was staring into that light with a smug expression, so clearly this was a good thing.

The light receded and Adora was standing there, except it wasn't exactly Adora.
She'd transformed into a tall, super ripped version of herself in a white and gold costume including shining gauntlets, a diadem, and outrageously flowing blonde hair.

Kate's jaw dropped.
"Oh my god, there's a lesbian Thor."

Next to her, Yelena was muttering something in Russian, and when Kate turned to look at her, she seemed impressed.

From across the room, Bow gave a whoop of delight.
"She-Ra!"

The super tall magic version of Adora turned to the clones and fixed them with a hard stare.

This magical transformation seemed to surprise the clones, as they paused for a moment, staring, before starting forward again at a near run. She-Ra was there to meet them, sending the first line sprawling with a mighty swing from her sword.

Glimmer and Catra were barely two steps behind, and they each engaged a target with renewed ferocity.

Yelena was still standing near Kate, a baton in each hand.
"Well Kate Bishop, are you ready?"

In response, Kate tucked away her bow and pulled out the sword, extending the blade and pointing it towards the clones. Then she froze.
"Wait, I wanted to say something cool, but I can't think of anything!"

Yelena definitely rolled her eyes at that one and gestured at the fight happening in front of them with one baton.
"By the time you think of something cool to say, the fight will be over."

Kate looked over and sure enough, having a giant magical sword girl on your side really evened the odds. She-Ra was bashing and blasting clones all over the place, flanked on either side by angry short girls.

"Yeah, okay, fine."
Kate bounced on her toes for a moment and then said, "It's sword time!"

The blonde next to her scoffed, but took off running, sliding past She-Ra gracefully and slamming her batons right into a clone's face.

Kate gave herself a few seconds to appreciate Yelena's moves, shook her head, and then rushed to enter the fray.
This time, it didn't take them long to gain the upper hand, driving their opponents back and back until they reached the collapsed corridor. When the final clone was motionless on the ground, five of them relaxed and tried to catch their breath.

Glimmer jogged over to where she could see Bow, who was still fiddling with the panels and staring at his tracker pad with increasing concern.

Now that the fight was over, they were all becoming aware that the rumbling had not stopped, and in fact, dust and small bits of rock were starting to shower down from the ceiling.

The lights all dimmed for a long moment and then flickered back on even brighter as the air around the tank crackled with another surge of electricity.

As the others came to join Glimmer, Bow abandoned his attempts and ran over.

“I can’t shut it down! I think they were trying to wake up the clone in the tank, but it's not working.”

They all looked over to the tank as the figure twitched once more, but the eyes remained closed.
A low rumble shook the ground under their feet and larger bits of stone began to shower down.

She-Ra was staring at the tank now, eyes narrowed.

“Everyone get behind me.”

“What are you going to do?” Catra asked.

“I’m going to destroy that body and make sure it never wakes up.”

“Okay,” Bow yelped, quickly scurrying closer to the exit and dragging Glimmer along by one arm.

Catra stayed right beside She-Ra though, crossing her arms.
“I’m not going anywhere princess.”

She-Ra’s response was fond and resigned.
“Of course not.”

Then, she raised her sword, which started to glow with a rich, golden light and aimed it right at the tank.
With a high, wordless shout, she sent a blast right at the tank.

The beam held there for a second, too bright to look at, and then the tank and everything around it exploded in a shower of debris. When the dust settled, Adora was standing there, sword held at her side and red jacket askew and covered in dust.
The tank had been obliterated.

Glimmer and Bow started jumping around, exclaiming joyfully. Catra leaned in against Adora and the blonde looped an arm around her partner's shoulder. Their quiet stood in marked contrast to the celebratory noise coming from their two friends.

Kate put away her sword and finally let her shoulders relax. When she turned to Yelena, the blonde woman had stowed her batons and wandered away towards the entrance.

She was trying to use her communicator to contact Director Hill, but based on her angry muttering, it wasn't working.

The brunette was starting to walk in her direction when the chamber started to rumble and shake, this time worse than before. There was a loud crack, and Kate spun in the direction of the sound to see that a fissure was forming in the ceiling near the spot where the tank had been.

She watched in fascinated horror as it spread across the rock and towards where they were all standing.
So far, it was only generating a shower of smaller debris, but the crack was quickly expanding towards a larger chunk of rock that was right above where Yelena was standing.

Panicked, Kate watched that rock start to detach from the ceiling, and without conscious thought, she sprinted towards Yelena and dived, wrapping the smaller woman in a tackle that flung them both out of the way to tumble across the floor.

With a loud boom, the huge chunk of rock slammed into the ground, and Kate closed her eyes, hoping she wasn't about to get squashed like a bug.

After a few moments, she opened one eye cautiously, pleased that she was still among the living.
As she started to sit up, a hand landed on her shoulder, gently but firmly halting her progress. She looked up to see Yelena's concerned face hovering over her.

"I'm okay," she managed to say, coughing slightly, "I'll probably have some awesome bruises, but I'm okay."

One of Yelena's arms wrapped around the back of her shoulders, propping her up carefully. The expression on her face wasn't her usual exasperation of smugness, but instead something more serious.

When Yelena spoke, her voice was more subdued than normal, but there was a note of deep fondness in it.

"Kate Bishop, you're such an idiot."

"I know."

There was a pause heavy enough for them to both feel it pressing against them before Kate continued in an almost hesitant tone, "But you love that about me."

"I do."

And then Yelena kissed her.

From a short distance away, Catra and Adora watched this scene unfold.
Catra muttered, "Wow, almost like looking into a mirror."
In response, Adora chuckled and dropped a kiss on Catra's head.

The two women kept kissing for what was definitely an inappropriate length of time given their surroundings, until finally Yelena pulled back, gripping Kate's upper arms firmly and gazing at her.

Kate whimpered at the loss of Yelena's lips against hers and met that intense gaze for a moment before saying in a very serious tone, "Please don't tell me you think that was a mistake."

Yelena smiled and said, in a low tone, "Absolutely not. I would just prefer to continue when we are not being stared at by my colleagues and a group of strange but endearing aliens."

The brunette let out a breath she didn't realize she'd been holding.
"Deal."

Yelena briefly rested her forehead against Kate's and then stood, extending a hand to help the archer to her feet.

Kate was finding it hard to take her eyes off Yelena, but once she did, she blushed as she realized that not only were the Etherians watching them with interest, but they were also being observed by some of the previously hijacked agents and other random humans who had woken up.

Then, the sound of boots on stone came from the other direction as a new group of S.H.I.E.L.D. agents led by Director Hill came through the exit tunnel.

Director Hill scanned the room taking in the confused humans at the far end, the piles of motionless clones, and the destroyed space where the tank had been and raised an eyebrow.

"I guess you don't need backup."

The next day, having been fully debriefed by S.H.I.E.L.D., the Etherians were gathered in Kate's apartment, preparing to return home.

As a parting gift, Kate had given them a bag of touristy Earth things and a variety of snacks.

While Kate showed off the various treats to an interested Adora, Catra pulled Yelena off to the side.

"Based on that kiss, I'm going to assume that I don't need to give you more advice about taking a chance on love."

Though Yelena's expression stayed stoic, a light flush dusted her cheekbones.

"I will keep your advice in mind for when things are hard."

Catra nodded at her and extended a hand which Yelena accepted.

"Take care of yourself. And her. Those idealistic hero types always need someone to watch their back."

"Yes, I think that you are correct," Yelena responded.

They both turned to look at the two taller women who were still excitedly digging through the large bag of snacks.

As if sensing the attention, Kate and Adora's heads turned in their direction.

Adora gave Catra a smile full of such love and warmth that Yelena had to look away.
But then she noticed that Kate was favoring her with a broad grin which made her heart skip a beat.
She must have been staring at Kate for too long, because at her side, Catra started snickering.

"Is it not time for you Etherians to return home?" she grumbled, but couldn't quite keep the warmth out of her tone.

After another round of extended goodbyes, they all went out to the roof where Adora uncloaked the ship and a ramp extended down almost to the rooftop.

"Come back and visit us anytime," Kate said. "But next time...maybe no major crises."

“You could come visit us too,” said Bow. “We could show you all the cool things on Etheria!”
He surreptitiously pressed something into Kate’s hand, and as he leaned in to give her one last hug, he whispered in her ear, “Those are the coordinates for Etheria.”

“Thanks Bow,” she whispered back.

Kate and Yelena watched as the Etherians boarded their ship, and waved goodbye one last time before the hatch closed and the ship lifted clear of the rooftop and vanished once more.

Kate laced her fingers together with Yelena’s and looked down at the shorter woman with a mischievous smile.

“So what now partner?”

Yelena’s only response was a wicked grin.

Chapter End Notes

> Thank you so much for sticking with the story!
> I hope you enjoyed the final chapter. It ended up being a long one, and therefore it took me much longer than I anticipated to finish it.
>
> If you have not checked out my other works yet, please do! I’ll be posting another update to my Bishova series in the near future and I have some new fics on the horizon. 💘

End Notes

Let me know what you think of this idea. I'd been wanting to mix it up a little after writing mostly She-Ra fanfic, and then I re-watched the Hawkeye series and had this idea for a cross-over.

In the MCU there have already been aliens, magical beings, and gods from other worlds visiting Earth, so I figured bringing the She-Ra folks over wouldn't be the wildest stretch.

This is my first attempt at writing crossover fiction, so any encouragement in the form of kudos and comments is greatly appreciated!

I'll be posting the next chapter in a couple weeks!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!